

READING EDITION

The Book of the Master and the Boy

How to Read This Book

You are holding a letter that began as a conversation. Long ago, a circle of believers and preachers came to me and said, in effect: you have set us free by reminding us of what we owe — and we owe on three counts. We owe thanks for the call you extended to us, thanks for the knowledge you placed in our hands, and thanks for the work you charged us to do. Show us, they asked, what a willing soul can actually do to render each of those thanks. We already know, from the limits religion sets, what is obligatory and what the student must ask and the teacher must answer. We already know, from the conduct of the righteous and the manners of seekers, what is easy enough to say. What we want now is the harder thing — the practice.

I am writing this book to answer them, and to answer you. Because if you have opened these pages, then in some way you are standing where they stood: aware that gratitude is not a feeling but a discipline, and wanting to be shown the shape of it.

Here is the frame I gave them, and that I now give you. The matter I am calling you toward is the one I honor above all else; may God be with His servants, complete this work in them, and ennoble those who answer Him. He has set, for the first of every thing, a last; and for the last of every thing, an end; and beyond every end, a further end. These successive ends are the houses of the hearts, and the keys that open them are acts of remembrance. The first key is affliction, the middle key is guidance, the last key is piety. Whoever has tried to grasp how things are actually built, and has stood honestly at the edge of what is within his own reach to obey, has already pointed himself toward guidance and begun to walk in the best way.



Shows the three successive keys that open the houses of the hearts.

So as you read, hold these three answers close, because the whole book turns on them. To thank the Master is to obey Him. To thank the knowledge is to act on it and to call others to it. To thank the work is to be patient with it and to call others to it as well. Everything that follows is an unfolding of those three sentences — and an invitation, across the centuries, for you to take them as your own.

The Three Thanks and Their Practices

Gratitude is a discipline, not a feeling

What is owed thanks	How thanks is rendered
The Master (the Call)	Obey Him
The Knowledge	Act on it and call others to it
The Work	Be patient with it and call others to it

Maps each of the three debts of gratitude to its corresponding practice.

1. The Seeker Who Found a Circle

Let me tell you about a man, and about what his life uncovered, because the doctrines of the righteous and the manners of the seekers are not abstractions — they walk on two feet, they begin somewhere, and what I want to set before you began in Persia.

There was a man from the people of Persia who was struck by the calamity of ignorance. I do not mean dullness — he was not dull. He possessed a heart of keen retention, a sound intellect, and a culture he had carefully acquired. By every ordinary measure he was furnished. And yet ignorance prevailed over him with regard to the one knowledge I have been describing, the knowledge that matters, and he grew up inside that ignorance without knowing he was inside it. He wavered in the heat of a thirst he could not name, and reckoned the glittering mirage to be the whiteness of water — so that when he came to it, he found nothing of it, and he found God there waiting for him, and his reckoning was settled. Then God honored his resting-place and lifted the cover off him, and found him in a light, and so guided him and found him out. God became his sustainer and enriched him with knowledge, until he became one of the scholars of Mount Tur and one of the dwellers of the Bayt al-Ma'mur.

When his guidance was completed and he had reached the end of his hope, a duty settled on him: to give thanks to his Maker and to toil for his Lord. He had heard a saying from his father — one that lived inside him the way the soul lives inside the body:

خَيْرُ الْحَسَنَاتِ إِحْيَاءُ الْمَوْتَى

"The best of good things is to raise the dead."

And he said within himself: I was dead and He revived me. I was ignorant and He taught me. I was not the first to be ignorant — so that I might be the one to bring knowledge to people before anyone else. And I am not the last to be ignorant — so that teaching might end with me. In truth, I must be one who gives thanks for this blessing and who passes this trust on to those who come after me, just as those before me passed

it on to me. This matter is the first of God's commandments, and it has reached me only through many causes — the first reaching the second, the second reaching the third — even though those who most loved it were the highest of God's creatures in the world. Then the veil was breached and the doors stormed, until it reached me. Am I, then, its endpoint and its end? No. Those who transmitted it and were faithful to it had the prior claim in respect of gains and virtues; and if their gains are not mine, then I rest on the fact that I am the one who gained from them through their work. And if their bounty does not exempt me from work, then I remain as poor as I was poor when I first sought knowledge. He said this within himself, and he knew that his duty was the very thing that was obligatory upon him, and that his last command was, in judgment, the same as his first.

So he left his family and his wealth for the sake of his Lord, answering Him and praying for the good, calling toward the obligation, yielding to Him the very thanksgiving that is His due. He passed through the peoples of the lands and through the tribes of the Arabs, scanning faces and casting questions — yet he found no answer and met no fellow seeker — until he came at last to the far reaches of the Island, al-Jazira. He entered a city of it at a time when its people were heedless. Recalling the signs and verifying the marks, he saw a group of the people of that land quarreling aimlessly over religion, wading in the depths of caprice. He sat down at a little distance, in seclusion from them, listening to their words and watching to see which of them held the best method.

He said to himself: These are the foremost in three qualities in living debate. First, they are conveying the argument. Second, they are of the people of the Umma. And third, they are closer in their awareness of religion, in their observing it together, in their searching for it together — and the seeker is on the verge of meeting what he seeks.

When they had finished their speech, they turned to him and said: Who are you, and where are you from, boy?

He said: I am a servant of God, and I am one of the dwellers of His Sanctuary.

They said: What is your need, and what is your work?

He said: My need has passed me by, and I am at work in seeking it.

They said: Did anything of what we said please you?

He said: All of it is strange — to one who marvels.

They said: Wonder is of two senses — praiseworthy and reprehensible.

He said: Yes, I have learned that. So too, words are praiseworthy and reprehensible.

They said: What is the praiseworthy kind, in your view?

He said: It is what is correct.

They said: And what is the correct?

He said: That whose origin was from God, and which calls to God.

They said: And what is the reprehensible?

He said: That whose origin was caprice, and which calls to something other than guidance.

They said: We believe you. Have you nothing of your own words for us to hear?

He said: I have nothing to say — but I am a follower of the right saying.

They said: Then let us hear from your words what you can show us of your doctrine. We have wearied you of your condition, and may your brotherhood be a blessing to us. We hope you will be a door of mercy that God has opened to us.

He said: Yes. And he listened to the people, and received them with his face.

Then he said: He who created the creation by His power made each thing equal to what He had decreed for it. He is the One who brought forth the highways of the pasture and made its outward and its inward free of caprices — He who is not ambiguous and is not reached by the study of mere traces. If imaginings are bewildered in their demand for Him, and minds grow careless in the search for His essence, still He does not appear within being so as to be possessed by His attributes, nor so that the intention of His path may be altered. Rather, He is generous. His knowledge is hidden by its very grace, and His secrets are protected by their proper family. His honor is the plumage of guidance; he is completed by the garment of piety, marked with the light of lights — a deposit in the breasts of the righteous, the keepers of the Word, the honor of the scribes, a trust which they discharge and a limit which they do not exceed. It is the rule of judgment and the bounties of the Most Merciful. He honored him and shielded him, protected him and concealed him, persuaded him of his rights and entrusted His covenants to him. So the thoughts of the thinkers do not reach him, and the schemes of the schemers do not arrive at him. His outward is a remembrance and an evidence for those who are guided, and his inward is a sure drink — its sky brought low to the beholders, its land paved for the seekers — and it has witnessed stations for the students. He has a guide for those who walk to Him, and signs whose wonders follow one upon another, pointing to Him by her parables. His path is preferred, his

method laid out in detail, his rulings binding, his Sunna are as laws, truthfulness has ennobled their doctrines, and justice has refined their gains. For every good there is a leader and a way, and He has made it a garden and a guide to its inner chamber. Then minds were compelled, by ignorance and by want, to seek knowledge and capacity. Blessed is He who has made night and day a succession for those who would be reminded or would give thanks; and may God bless those He chose from among them to worship Him and made a warning to the worlds.

Then he said: Fear God. Fear those who fear Him. Fear Him with the fear of one who would please Him. Seek knowledge. Learn. Work. And have mercy.

2. The Boy Who Followed

His eyes filled, and the tears stopped his speech. He took his leave of the people, rose, and set out. They wept — moved by the warmth of him, by the eloquence of what he had said — and for a moment they wanted to rise and go with him. But what they actually did, to keep up the appearance of courtesy, was to celebrate him where they stood. They did not know what they had just consented to. They went off to their houses.

One of them did not. A youth from the group — the youngest, and the most thoughtful — followed him. Discipline had sharpened his mind; reflection had filled his heart; and now, on top of all that, the Master's words had been laid before him as a gift. The boy had a father who was a great sheikh of the Arabs, among the most honored of them, and among the most listened-to in matters of religion. So he kept the Master's company, with the Master's permission, until the journey reached its end. The Master then took him inside, called for food, and when the

conversation had wound down and they were settled into the quieter, easier kind of talk, the boy began.

"O wise one," he said, "I have spoken and listened and preached in my time. I have been instructed. I have dressed the religion in the finest ornament I could find and longed for it in the noblest way I knew, and I have called others to it through the most honorable of its trusts. Minds were hungry for a question from you, because of the openings your words cut into our hearts. An excellence like this can only come from someone in whom the inner has been made whole as a teacher, and the outer has expanded into wisdom — for he is the seventh fountain of wisdom drawn from a firm origin, his blessings reach the worlds, and the branches of his branches are fruit for the seekers. I hope you may be one of those blessed branches, because of what I see in you: nobility of opinion, soundness at the core, completeness of mind. You said that minds are driven by ignorance to seek knowledge and capacity. My mind is among the most needy and the most destitute. May I have life from the way?"

The Master answered. "The One who created the creatures by His power did not create them in vain. He did not create them already learned, and He does not abandon them inside the misguidance of ignorance, nor is He content for them to rest in stupidity of culture or to wear the garments of unknowing. He has made for them, as their way out of all that, the very road by which He composed their constitution and finished their making. He gave them hearing, and eyes, and hearts full of lights — as a sign of His dignity toward them and as an argument against them. Then He placed the treasures of His wisdom and the marks of His will in doctrines that please Him, lodged with His elect among His creation. He entrusted them with the religion, called them to it, and laid upon them the duty of answering Him, using the instrument we have named — so

that He might separate the evil from the good. The seeker, by his very asking, comes to see; the one who is ignorant even of his own backwardness becomes known. After His Messengers no one has any argument left against Him, and no excuse to go astray."

"The lack of any excuse has frightened me," the boy said, "and the existence of the evidence has made me want it. I am begging you for a proof. I will be a servant to you."

"God did not create men as scholars," the Master said. "He created them small, ignorant, knowing nothing. There is no great except after small, no scholar except after ignorance. Smallness is the prelude to greatness; ignorance is a guide to knowledge. Knowledge itself is not bearable except when something has gone before it — some prior knowing, quicker to the heart than the thing itself, smoother to the understanding — so that the learner is steadied in his first imaginings, his obligations are made lighter for him, his wings begin to shiver toward it, and his mind can carry its meaning. This is the way of God with His servants. Let us not deviate from it in religion by our own opinion, and let us not follow anything alongside it except the way itself."

"I am too small for what I want," the boy said, "so raise me. I am ignorant of what I have asked for, so teach me. I am bound by your favor, so have mercy on me. You yourself were once in this very situation. God forbid that you should withhold from me — through my own hands — the blessing of that great trial God once laid upon you, the one for which He is to be thanked through your person. I know what it is to be in the suffering of ignorance and the helplessness of having no resources."

"The state you describe is exactly as you say," the Master answered, "but I will not be merciful to you by doing for you what you must do for yourself. Every claim is accepted only when it is true. Knowledge is no

benefit unless it is acted upon, and action is no benefit unless it is accepted. The truthfulness of speech is its justice. The proof of knowledge lies in the open ways and in the documented exemplars that have lasted through the lands, by which night and day themselves have been distinguished from each other. Do not pursue an argument carelessly, and do not dismiss one carelessly. Do not accept anything on imitation alone — because the first doubt that rises against it will tear it out of your heart. But do not reject the proof of an argument either, or you will leave an opening through which falsehood enters. Do not let your own opinion make inquiry and consensus useless. Think well of me without reservation. Strive in your questioning without suspicion. Seek the religion. Seek someone like yourself. And seek God's help in your matter. God does not waste the reward of the one who seeks, and does not deprive of reward anyone He sees pursuing the good."

"You have dealt justly with yourself," the boy said, "in a way both fitting and effective, and you have set the truth out in the best phrasing of it. I ask God's help, and I ask you about this matter you are calling me to: what is it? Whose is it? To whom does it belong?"

"It is the religion of God that He has accepted," the Master said, "and the only one from whom it can be accepted is Him. He delivered it first to the elite among His Messengers, and then to the whole of His creation in general. The one specially favored with it owes thanks for it, action upon it, and a call to others to take it up. The one deprived of it owes the searching after it, so that he comes to know it, and the obedience due to whoever guides him to it."

"This favor that God singled out for His friends," the boy asked, "are all such favors equal in excellence, or do some surpass others?"

"Have we not said that every kind of knowledge has its predecessor who taught it," the Master said, "and that each predecessor carried his own portion — so that they stand at graded ranks before their Lord, each one accountable for what he has acquired? Then every one of them is set right in his very making by the merit of his bestowal, and so becomes a mercy upon God's servants."

"This thing you are calling me to," the boy said, "is it that favor itself, or is it something other than it?"

"It is neither identical with it, nor wholly other than it," the Master said. "It is from it — the way a single chamber of water is from the breadth of the Euphrates. I am calling you to what God has accepted for His servants and ennobled. It is the day on which I bring it to completion — precious, secure, generous, hidden. Its honor, along with its reward, is dignity for the one who lifts it up. Its retribution is debasement for the one who loses it. Its outward form is figures; its inner reality is knowledge. Its wisdom is a yoke. Its justice is plain. This is what I am calling you to."

"What makes you more exclusively entitled to this matter than anyone else?" the boy asked. "If you claim it is from God for creation in general, then everyone has the same claim on it that you do. What gives you a greater right than they to the name of truth — has this matter come to you by some route that bypassed them?"

"There is no scholar who speaks a single word of truth," the Master said, "except that he has taken it from the very origins we ourselves have taken it from. In this they agree with us, by acknowledging it from us and among themselves. What separated us from them was this: they abandoned those principles while we held fast to them. We obeyed where they disobeyed. We preserved what we were entrusted with where

they squandered it. We did what we were commanded where they neglected. So they agree with us in acknowledgement and disagree with us in fact. Their acknowledgement is a witness for us. Their loss is the sign of their poverty toward us and of their need for what is in our hands. They are like brothers who inherited a great wealth from their father and divided it between themselves. Some of them squandered their share until they fell into poverty. Others kept it, preserved it, traded with it, and the wealth in their hands multiplied. Then the poor among the brothers came back to the wealthier ones, to serve them and seek some of their bounty. So too those who lost the way of their Messengers come now, in their ignorance, to seek knowledge from the people of the original sources, the generous ones. The proof that we are more deserving of the truth than they is precisely their need of us, their dependence on what is in our hands — so that our knowledge has become the answer to their ignorance, our garment covers their nakedness, and our abundance satisfies their hunger. The truth is binding upon anyone who would be virtuous. The credit belongs to the one who confers the favor. Thanks is owed to the one who bestows the kindness."

"As for your superiority over them, that has become clear," the boy said. "And as for the argument of truth, it has been established for every honest seeker. But what is your argument against me — when I already agree with what you have said, stand by what you have described, deny what you have denied, and recognize the truth and its excellence along with falsehood and its people?"

"My argument against you," the Master said, "is the same as my argument against them — through my disagreement with them in description, and my agreement with them in meaning."

"How can that be," the boy asked, "when I acknowledge the truth to its owner, and they deny it?"

"If their denial is what keeps you back from joining them," the Master said, "they too have refrained from what is forbidden to them. So what is the benefit of acknowledgement without an agent to put it into effect?"

"Then take me to the people of truth, so that I may know them," the boy said, "or to an agent who can prove it to them. Show me which of the two you can do."

"Do you not see," the Master said, "that you have been made to need the proof of the rightful owner of the truth, or his agent, in exactly the way the public has been made to need a proof of the truth? Action has separated you from them, just as ignorance has joined you to them."

"I have believed," the boy said. "The matter has become clear to me."

"Have I not firmly established my argument against you and against the public?"

"Yes," he said.

"Can anyone prove to others a truth he holds only for himself?"

"No one is able to do that," he said.

"Then the argument has been established," the Master said, "against you and against the public. Nothing remains but submission, and the appointing-over-yourself of the one whom you cannot do without and who can do without you."

"As for my poverty," the boy said, "I acknowledge it. As for the One who is rich while I am in need — I ask of Him, and I ask Him to have mercy on me."

"Have you ever seen someone driven by poverty to seek the help of a generous man," the Master asked, "obtain anything from him except by

acquisition or by favor?"

"Yes," the boy said. "Nothing can be obtained except by acquisition or by favor."

"And do the people of favor reach the people of grace by way of acquisition?"

"No," he said.

"Then seek this matter by work," the Master said, "and you will be granted it as a merit. Do not seek it by flattery, or you will be deprived of it."

"You are the key to goodness, and its guide," the boy said. "Show me the more meaningful of the two roads, and the nearer of them to guidance. I am the most destitute of those who follow you."

"My son," the Master said, "there is nothing more for you, and nothing more is expected of me. What you hoped to receive from me has reached you. But there are limits not to be crossed, and conditions not to be forgotten."

"Set whatever limits you love," the boy said, "and lay down whatever conditions you approve. I hope you will find me patient under them, and grateful for your kindness."

3. The Five Conditions and the Covenant

When he had finished speaking those words to me — that there were limits not to be crossed and conditions not to be forgotten, and I had told him to set whatever limits he loved and lay down whatever

conditions he approved — he did not delay. He named the first limit at once, and he named it in a way I have never been able to forget.

"The first of the limits," he said, "is to uphold the outward meaning of the Book and its laws, and to act upon what you know of it. Whoever does for God what he knows, God will guide him to what he does not know."

I want you to sit with that for a moment, because I sat with it for a long time. He did not say: learn more. He did not say: find a hidden meaning. He said: act on what you already know. The road to what is concealed begins in what is plain. The unknown is not unlocked by curiosity; it is unlocked by obedience to what is already in your hands.

But I was young, and I had a young man's instinct to complicate what is simple. So I said to him: "There are many Books, and all of them are from Allah. For every Book there is a scholar from among creation who adheres to it, and they are all united in safeguarding it and in the religion it contains."

I thought I was being generous. I thought I was honoring every revelation. He saw what I was actually doing — softening the claim of the last Book by spreading it across all of them — and he did not let me get away with it.

"We have returned to our earlier words," he said, "and we now need to settle what should not have needed settling."

"How is that?" I asked.

"By your saying that the Books are many," he said, "and that all of them are from Allah, and that each has a scholar of its own. Have they then issued the verdict that the words of God and His Books cancel one

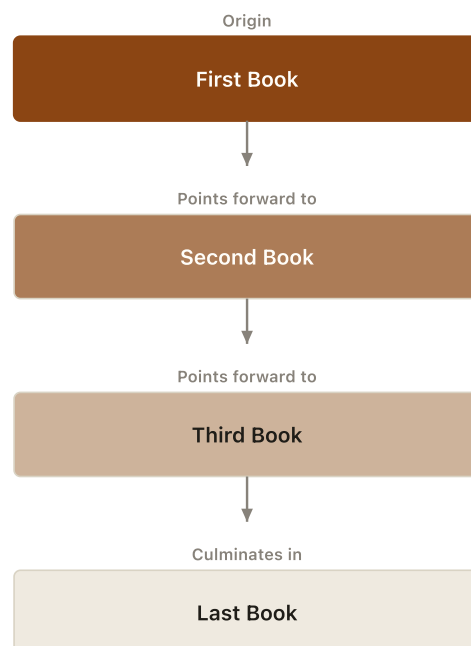
another out — that the first of them gives the lie to the last, and the last gives the lie to the first?"

The question struck me silent for a moment, because of course they had not. "I do not think so," I said. "But what is the proof of it?"

And here he gave me an argument I have carried with me ever since.

"If created beings had been able to do what is in the first Book," he said, "then it would have pointed them to the second; and if they did what is in the second, it would have pointed them to the third — so that the work culminates in the last of them, because the last is what the earlier ones were pointing toward. Even though all of them are from Allah, the later is nearer to the present age and clearer in doctrine, since it copies and confirms what came before it, and nothing came after it to copy or supersede it."

The Arc of the Revealed Books



Shows how each earlier Book points forward to the next, culminating in the last revelation that confirms and supersedes them all.

You see what he was doing. He was not setting the Books against one another; he was showing me that they form a single arc. Each earlier revelation was a hand pointing forward. The last Book is the place all the hands were pointing. To honor the earlier Books is to arrive at the one they were leading toward; to scatter your loyalty across all of them as if they were peers is to misunderstand the arrow they were drawing.

Something settled in me then. "I have believed," I said. "The knowledge of the truth and the sign of truthfulness have been shown to me. I am holding to the limits you have ordered me to keep — so what are your conditions for me?"

He answered without hesitation, and he counted them off one by one, as a man counts coins he has weighed many times.

"My conditions for you are five," he said. "Do not be absent if I summon you. Do not conceal anything from me if I ask you. Do not question me until I answer you. Do not request anything until I begin with you. And do not mention what passes between us to your father."

I want you to hear those five again, slowly, because each one is a discipline of the seeker that the modern reader will be tempted to dismiss. Be present when called. Hide nothing when asked. Do not interrupt with questions before the answer has come. Do not grasp before what is meant for you is offered. And keep this between us — even from your father.

I accepted four of them in a breath. The fifth pressed on me.

"I will do all that you have mentioned," I said, "it is easy for me set against what I have hoped from you. But how can I manage the matter of my father? He is one of the heaviest trials upon me, and one of the

heaviest I have to bear — so will you permit me to remove myself from him?"

I thought withdrawal would be cleaner. I thought distance would protect the secret better than nearness. He saw further than I did.

"Withdrawing from him would be a sign to others," he said. "Rather, stand with him and his estate with some outward agreement, and keep all this your secret and conceal it. God will be enough for us against his evil and the evil of others."

This is a teaching the impatient never accept: that the surface of your life can keep doing what it has always done, while the truth of your life begins to take a new shape underneath it. He did not tell me to flee my father. He told me to stay, to keep the outward form, and to hide the inward turn — because flight is itself a confession, and the secret was not ready to be confessed.

Then we parted. And the part of the story I find hardest to tell is the part that came next, because it was nothing — it was absence. We were apart for a long time. I knew nothing but what the law had brought me to stop at. I did not know where he was settled. I could not seek him out, because the condition he had laid on me was to wait until he summoned me. And the absence lengthened. He was showing me, by his silence, the very patience and endurance he was asking of me — letting me feel the cost of the discipline before he gave me more of the doctrine.

At last, on a quiet night when creation was still and the informers had grown forgetful, when we had settled together in an assembly, I came upon him as my need pressed close and I was able at last to be alone with my companion. I rejoiced over him. I fell into prostration in thanks.

When I raised my head he was looking at me.

"I saw you prostrating in thanksgiving," he said. "Thanksgiving before the work inherits the obligation; thanksgiving cut short after the work makes the works themselves vain."

Read that twice. He was telling me that gratitude offered before a task is begun makes the task binding — you have thanked God for it, so now you owe it. And gratitude that is broken off after a work is finished empties the work itself. Gratitude is not a posture at the start or the end; it is the medium the work moves through.

"All your words are truthful," I said, "and all your works are mastery. I thank you for your kindness, and I hope from you for yet more of it."

"Thanksgiving is owed," he said, "because gratitude is what makes thanksgiving increase. Your right has been fulfilled — so come to me with your heart, open your understanding, and listen to what is presented to you."

"I have brought the instrument of understanding," I said, "and I have taken up the instrument of hearing. Say what seems good to you."

What he said then was the thing I had waited the long absence to receive.

"Religion has a key," he said, "that opens it and closes it, like that which distinguishes between forbidden union and lawful marriage."

I felt the weight of the image at once. A key — one key — that distinguishes the lawful from the unlawful, the true from the false, in the way that a marriage contract distinguishes a sanctified union from a forbidden one. Without the key, the outward act might look the same and yet stand on opposite sides of an absolute line.

"This key you have mentioned is great in the sight of Allah," I said, "since it is what distinguishes between the lawful and the unlawful, between truth and falsehood. So what is it?"

"It is the covenant of Allah," he said, "which establishes His rights, gathers His obligations, makes Paradise binding for His friends — the rope of God upon His earth, and the safe haven among His servants. I will recite it to you, and bind you to it."

The rope of God upon His earth. The safe haven among His servants. He was speaking of

وَاَعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا

"And hold fast, all together, to the rope of God, and do not be divided."

— the rope by which a servant is fastened to his Lord, the cord that keeps the one who grips it from falling. The covenant, he was telling me, is that rope. It is not a sentiment, not an inclination; it is the binding instrument by which the rights of God are established over a life, by which the obligations are gathered into one place, by which Paradise itself is made binding upon those whom God has taken as His friends.

"Yes," I said. "Take from me whatever you love. I do not refuse your opinion, and I do not transgress your command."

And so he set about reciting the covenant to me, conveying it to me word by word and binding me fast by it. I could not contain myself for awe. The tears poured down from the intensity of the instruction. I had thought, before that night, that I knew what it was to be moved; I had not known. He recited to the end of the covenant, and when it was

finished I praised God and glorified Him, and I thanked Him for what He had granted me. I understood — and I want you to understand that I mean understood, not merely believed — that by accepting their pledge I had become part of the Party of God,

أُولَئِكَ حِزْبُ اللَّهِ ۚ أَلَا إِنَّ حِزْبَ اللَّهِ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ

"Those are the Party of God. Truly, the Party of God — they are the successful."

— part of the company of His friends. I fell silent then, in my composure, the way a man falls silent when something irrevocable has happened to him and he is still inside the first moments of it.

And he began to expound, and to explain.

4. How Creation Is Made

He began with the cause behind the cause, and the cause behind that, until I understood he was not going to speak to me about anything small. The first thing he set before me — the first of the causes of the manifest order, the beginning of its very creation — was this. God is the Creator of things and the One who composes them. He brought them into being and originated them. Do not think of Him as the first of every first created thing, He having taken priority as a kind of evidence of what was created; that is not what is meant. He is the First of all firsts, and the Inheritor of every thing. There is nothing before Him to be measured against, and nothing after Him that will not return.

He began the creation of what was created out of light. From that light three words branched. The first of them is the will. From the will

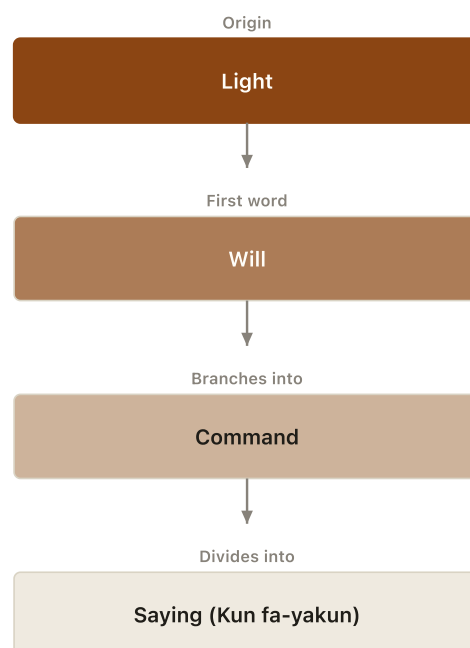
branched the command. And the command divides into the saying — that He says to what He wills: "Be," and it is.

كُنْ فَيَكُونُ

"Be, and it is."

So mark the order, because it is not decorative: first the will, then the command, then the saying. These are three words. From them is derived كُنْ — two letters — and فَيَكُونُ — five letters. That is seven letters, and from those seven letters branch seven things.

The Three Words of Creation



Traces how creation issues from light through the three words — will, command, saying — culminating in the divine utterance Kun fa-yakun.

From the light He created air — and air is the first of them. It is singular, without consort, unique among the things, a mixture that surrounds everything but is itself surrounded by nothing. It is the proof of the One

concerning whom it is said that there is nothing like Him. Then He created out of those three words three further things: water, darkness, and light. Then He created the heavens and the earth. From water He created smoke. From the heat of darkness He created condensation. From light He created fire. Three things branching from three things before them — and each became consort to its origin, because it was drawn out of it. And the seventh — air — encompasses all of them, presiding over them as the unique encompasses the paired. This was the beginning of creation, and this was the beginning of things.

The Seven Principles of Creation

Each derivative becomes consort to its origin; air, singular and without consort, encompasses all

Origin	Derived Consort
Water	Smoke
Darkness	Condensation
Light	Fire

Pairs each derived element with its origin among the three primordial words, with air encompassing all as the unique seventh.

When creation had been established on seven principles, and the path of forms laid down on the basis of likeness and analogy, He created out of smoke the seven heavens and their signs, and He created out of condensation the seven earths and their powers. Those seven branch from these seven origins, and nothing in what you see above you or beneath you escapes that lineage.

Then look — he said to me, and I want you to look with me — to the signs of the heavens and the powers of the earth. What are they, and what is the proof of them? We return to the three words and to the letters which created the seven, namely "the will to command by saying." That phrase is twelve letters. Its signs in the heaven are the twelve constellations. Its witnesses are seven kingdoms. Its signs upon the earth are twelve, of which ten belong to the seven islands. And its proofs are seventeen seas. These are the signs of the heavens and of the earth — signs we pass through every day of our lives, signs presented to us so plainly that we have stopped seeing them.

Then the heavens and the earth were veiled in darkness from the black heat — which is the authority of the earth. Then He pierced that veil with His lights, and light and darkness were intermingled. They are two distinct realities. He distinguished between them by night and day, by two signs. He made the night, and its sign a path of darkness, and He apportioned it. He made the day, and its sign a path of light, and He apportioned it. He adorned the night, in its darkness, with the moon and the stars; and the day shines, in its light, gleaming through the sign of the sun. Then the days produced states that hover between night and day, and these are the seven days. And the sign of each is this: every day has twelve hours, and every night has twelve hours — the twelve again, do you see, returning under another face.

When the creation of things was combined with these principles, He made them in pairs — male and female. I do not mean male and female in the literal, bodily sense only. I mean it in the deeper sense: the active and the receptive. From there the custom of pairing went forth as the very habit of creation, and He created all its essences in this manner — animals: humans, beasts, birds, and the creatures that crawl. Then the same custom extended into speech itself, and speech too became paired:

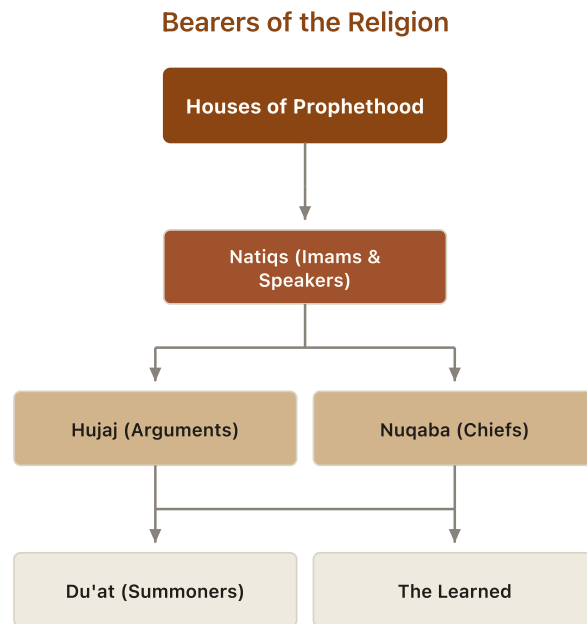
adjectives and descriptions, names and meanings. Glory be to Him who created all pairs, and made them manifestations of His command, exemplars of His religion, and signs of His power — pointing by things to their origins, and by parables to their interpretations.

Then He pierced it with His light, opened it with His command, created it by His knowledge, and sealed it among His names with the letters of

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

"In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful."

When He had completed all of them by His making and composed them in pairs by His measure, He selected for Himself, from the choicest of His will and the secrets of His unseen, a great knowledge and a clear light. He made these two a religion — the religion by which God draws His creation back to Himself. Then He honored that religion with laws and with books, made it manifest by parables and by the sunna, and appointed, from the choicest of His creation, banners and signs and rulers. He made them the houses of His prophethood, the treasuries of His knowledge and His wisdom, His interpreters and the bearers of His revelation. Their succession in His earth is itself the evidence of the path of salvation — both in the apparent (the *zahir*) and in the inner (the *batin*). Some of them are imams and speakers — *natiqs*. Some are arguments — *hujaj* — and chiefs — *nuqaba*. Among them are the summoners — *du'at* — to the good, and among them are the learned. In their dwellings they are like the stars of heaven.



Shows the ranked bearers of the religion descending from the prophetic houses through arguments and chiefs down to the summoners.

By them the works were called, and by their names the parables were named. Their imam is like the great sun among the lights, surpassing all sight; he is their apparent and their likeness. The argument, and the gate of their imam, is like the shining moon — its appearance and its likeness. Their summoners are like the manifest stars — the zawahir — their appearances and their likenesses.

All of the pairs I have described to you are at once apparent and inward — figure and likeness, the seen face and the meaning behind the seen face. The apparent are the seven heavens; their inner counterparts are the seven speakers, the natiqs — and the first of the speakers are the messengers. The seven earths are outwardly parables; their inner counterparts are the imams of guidance. For each of those imams there are twelve chiefs, the nuqaba, and their counterparts in the seven heavens are the twelve constellations. Likewise, each imam of guidance

has twelve arguments — hujaj — by which God is invoked upon his people; and their counterparts in the earth are the twelve islands, the dwellings of the chiefs. On every island stands an argument. And for every argument there are summoners — sometimes many, sometimes few. He increases in creation what He wills, in order that the argument of God may reach His creation, so that people will have no argument against God after the messengers.

Through these causes — the causes of God I have been describing to you — the argument of God reaches His creation, and His justice appears among them, outwardly and inwardly. The inner, the batin, is the religion of God by which He has bound the saints of God. The outer is the laws of religion and their likenesses. So the religion of the laws is one and the same; and the laws of religion are a body and a guide. There is no body without a soul, because the soul is its life. And there is no power for the soul except in the body, because the body is its instrument. So it is with the apparent laws and their likenesses: they have no foundation except in the inner religion, because that inner religion is their light and their meaning, the spirit of life inside them. And the inner has no strength except in the outer, because the outer is its body and its proof. The knowledge of this world cannot be perceived except through the outer. The knowledge of the hereafter cannot be perceived except through the inner. Not a single letter of the letters of the subordinate, and not a single saint of the saints, can be perceived through the outer alone in any abundance — because the parables are too many and the laws too wide.

The more one speaks of this, the more there is yet to be said. But wisdom hides its truths, and conceals its last from its first, because of its preciousness and the purity of its essence. The bright lights of wisdom cover one another as the light of the sun covers the light of the moon and the stars and weakens them. And so it is with the words of wisdom

— they adorn the tongue of the wise, but the deepest of them lie always beneath the brightest of them, waiting.

5. The World as Parable

And so the boy turned from wisdom's veiled brilliance to a question nearer at hand — the very ground we walk on. He said: this world, in which so vast a creation has been set, has many people, the first of them and the last, and they do not agree about it. Some have given themselves to it entirely, sought it, and could see no merit except in heaping more of it upon themselves. Others reproach it and practice asceticism within it, though they too cannot dispense with it altogether — for all that is forbidden in it is much, while only a little of it is forbidden. I have heard you say nothing about this world. What do you say of it?

The scholar answered: no one will ever truly reproach this world — not the scholar, not the ignorant. The ignorant man knows its virtue precisely through his ignorance of what lies beyond it; the scholar knows its virtue through the virtue of its meaning. The only one who reproaches the world is an ignorant man — and how can it be permissible for the creation to reproach the action of the Creator? Say rather this: the world has been set up for those who would see seven things, branching from seven origins — heaven, earth, darkness, light, vessels, prosperity, and misery. These are seven qualities, and from each of them seven further qualities branch out.

The heavens, he said, are seven. The earths are seven. The light has seven days and seven nights: Saturday is for slumber and rest; Sunday is for the limits and the sunna; Monday is for the bladder, in the great meaning, al-Kabir; Tuesday has three houses — apparent, inward, and the inward of the subtle; Wednesday is for the four, which is the

sanctuary; Thursday is the fifth of the causes of God; and Friday is the greatest law of God. The darkness is the seven nights of paradise for the seven days — a night for each day, a day for each night.

As for the vessels, they too are seven: camels, horses, mules, donkeys, elephants, oxen, and ships — for by these seven vessels the regions of the earth are traversed. Camels for the sands, horses for the plains, mules for the mountains, donkeys for the short destinations, elephants for marshes and wasteland, oxen for the salt-flats and the thickets, and ships for the seas. Seven vessels for seven domains.

The blessings of this world, he went on, rest upon seven: air, water, light, darkness, food, clothing, and marriage. Air is the medium between sky and earth, and the life of the animal. Water — he would come back to water. Light is the substance of sight. Darkness is the increase of vegetation. Food is the sustenance of the body. Clothing, even in paradise, wards off harm. Marriage is the seed of reproduction and the cause of offspring. Some of these are the keys of every good; some are the mines of blessings. Which of them is blameworthy, when all of them are the gifts of God and His blessings, for which His servants should give thanks? And their opposites in misery are seven as well: heat, cold, hunger, thirst, fear, sickness, and death. Seven things to be borne with patience — and one must know what they mean.

Blessings and Their Opposites

Every gift of the world has a corresponding trial to be borne with patience

Blessings	Miseries
Air	Heat
Water	Cold
Light	Hunger
Darkness	Thirst
Food	Fear
Clothing	Sickness
Marriage	Death

Pairs the seven blessings of the world against their seven counterparts in misery.

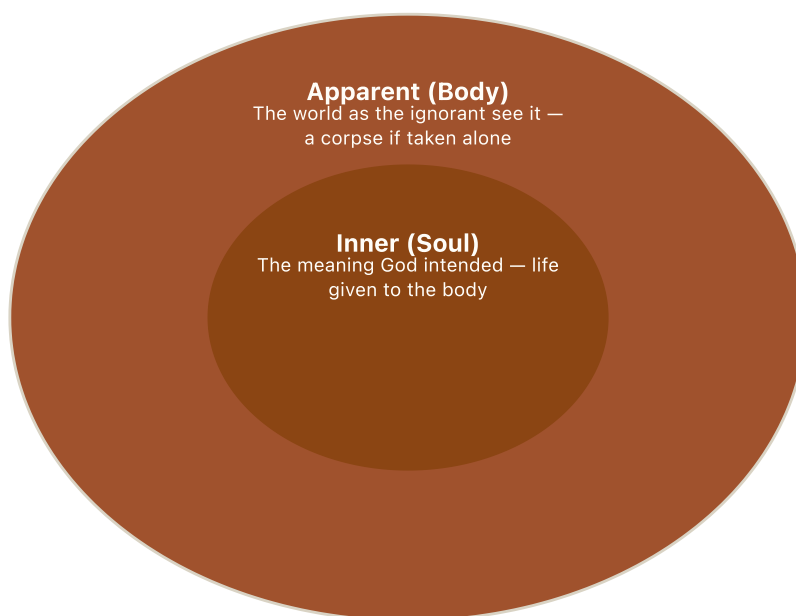
The boy heard this and said: these are the attributes of this world, and I do not doubt that anything in it is other than what the Creator has made and composed. Then what do the scholars mean when they censure the world, or when they sing its praise? And what do the ignorant mean when they praise it? It seems the ignorant have arrived somehow at the meaning, even in their ignorance — and if that is so, the rightness of their case forces the scholars into error, because the scholars contradict the people of ignorance in every sense.

The scholar answered him gently. The scholars did not err in censuring this world — but no creature knows what they mean by it. The ignorant did not perceive the meaning of what they were praising in the world. They are correct to praise it, but they are ignorant of what their praise is praising. The one who is ignorant of a thing is merely accustomed to it.

Then show me, the boy said, the truth of what the scholars say, so I may rightly believe them. Distinguish for me the speech of the people of ignorance by whatever exposes its falsehood, since the apparent points the other way. If my chest is weary of this ignorance, I do not hope for relief except by His knowledge.

The scholar said: this world, and everything in it that I have described to you, has an apparent and an inner. It has no standing strength except in Him, because He is to it as the soul is to the body. Whoever knows the soul, the body is graced for him. Whoever does not know the soul and confesses only the body is bowed over a corpse — and corpses are forbidden. That is why the scholars forbade this world: because it is dead. They fled from a dead thing which God has forbidden, until life come to it from where God wills. And the people of ignorance lie when they praise this world, because they did not know its inner meaning or what God intended by it. They imagined God created the world for some other meaning — but God did not create things in vain. If the world and what is in it had been created for the world alone, He would have created in it a fading creation with no consequence and no meaning. Every action without consequence is play, and every meaningless speech is falsehood — and God is more exalted than that.

Apparent and Inner of the World



Shows the world's outer body sustained by an inner soul that is God.

The boy said: the truthfulness of the scholars is established, and their virtue and excellence are proven — as is the falsity and the lying of the people of ignorance, by what has appeared from the argument. And now we have an inner knowledge of the world and of what is in it. I see that the distress I complained of to you has been lifted.

The scholar said: and what is the reward of the one who brought you out of the distress of poverty into the capacity of welcome?

He said: thanks and praise.

And what is the reward of the one who brought you out of the distress of ignorance into the capacity of knowledge?

He said: obedience and action.

The scholar said: this world and everything of its kind is an apparent for the hereafter, which lies within it as its soul and its life. Whoever seeks

this world without knowledge of the hereafter, his quest is misguidance — for his quest has no meaning and no consequence. But whoever seeks in this world for the hereafter, while believing in it, his quest has meaning and his quest has consequence, and his quest is praiseworthy.

The boy said: I have believed. So show me the features of this world and what is in it, and grant me parables of it from within.

The scholar said: God has not created anything in this world — no animal upon the earth, no bird that flies with its wings, nothing wet, nothing dry, no inanimate thing such as mountains, stones, trees, or minerals, no gold, no silver, no gemstone — nothing at all, great or small, that is not made by parable. Do you not see that even the atom, for all its smallness and subtlety, has limits — in front of it, behind it, to its right, to its left, above it, below it? Those are six limits, and the seventh is itself. So too is everything God has created, from the ant and the mosquito to whatever is above them in the heavens and the earth, and whatever is between them, great or small. This is the parable: each of them has six limits, and the seventh among them is the proof — pointing to the six origins from which all things were brought into being. The air around them is the seventh, the encompassing one. If you open your heart to questions and consider the parables, you will meet all of them in their form from the inner pairs. So ask what seems good to you.

The boy said: then what is the likeness of the heaven, with its height and its breadth above things, and its diameters that surround all things?

The scholar said: it is like the speaking Imam — al-Imam al-Natiq — who is exalted above all creation by his virtue and his high degrees, and who contains all rulings, and the rulings of the Shari'a, by reason of his knowledge.

What is the likeness of the zodiac, the boy asked, and of its other stars?

They are like the twelve chiefs, the nuqaba, the chiefs of the speaking Imam. Its stars are his summoners, the du'at, who call to good with the permission of their Lord.

What is the likeness of the earth and its breadth, which has been made a foundation for this creation and is praised?

It is like the gate, the bab, of the speaking Imam during his lifetime, and his successor, the wasi, after his death. It is a guide for the people and a resolve for those who seek guidance, while they are knowers of the parables and of the inner interpretation, the ta'wil.

And the twelve islands in the earth?

Parables of the twelve arguments, the hujaj — the arguments of the guardians.

The rivers and the springs?

The likeness of those who call to the good, the du'at.

The seven kingdoms of the heavens and their heavens?

They are the causes between God and the speaker, the natiq, and they belong to Him. These are the seven, and the orbits — al-falak — for these are the causes of the great God.

The seven seas?

These are the causes between God and the imams of the speaker. Take note of those causes.

And the salt water, the boy pressed on, and the fresh water, and their difference upon the earth?

The salt water, the scholar said, is like the knowledge of the apparent in which there is no da'wa and no summoners — for salt water yields neither sowings nor anything else. The fresh water is like the knowledge of the esoteric. As for the springs in the earth and the water that flows above it — knowledge is just so: the esoteric is the knowledge of the hidden, the apparent is the knowledge of the summoners, and the inward is the hidden esoteric.

But how, the boy asked, did water come to be like knowledge?

Because water, the scholar said, is the life of every animal. And in just this way knowledge is the life of every world.

The boy lifted his eyes higher. What is the air, then, that surrounds all things?

The air, the scholar said, is too great to be set as a parable.

Is it greater — or are the heavens and the earth as great as it?

Glory be to Allah. He is greater than both. The capacity of the earth within the air is like a ring lying on a flat plain. The expanse of the atmosphere within the sky is like a ring lying on a flat plain. And the breadth and the diameters of the sky within the capacity of the air are like an egg lying on a flat plain. Whoever has the mind to grasp this image will have proof.

And what is its meaning? the boy asked.

It is proof of the One who has nothing like Him — a refutation of what they associate with Him.

But, the boy said carefully, did the Creator not say —

فَلَا تَضْرِبُوا لِلَّهِ الْأَمْثَالَ

"Do not strike parables for God"?

The scholar said: and did He not also say —

وَلِلَّهِ الْمَثَلُ الْأَعْلَىٰ

"And to Allah belongs the highest similitude"?

Glory be to Him, the boy said, who has placed enigmas in His book that come from His own door. You are one of its gates — show us how this is.

The scholar said: everything has a meaning, and the meaning of parables is this — the apparent is evidence of the hidden. He has forbidden that He be measured by anything He created. One does not say "this is like God" as one says "this is like the Imam," or "this is like the hujja," or "this is like the da'i." Their likenesses became signs that point to them and distinguish them. Why then should it be necessary, in matters of His greatness, that the Creator be measured against something of His creation? It is not said, "this is like God." Rather, parables are taken according to their meanings, because their meanings carry signifiers: the lesser indicates the greater, and the greater indicates the supreme. That is why He said, "And to Allah belongs the highest similitude" — meaning the highest proof. For there is no evidence higher than the proof of God. He is the air: highest above the heavens and the earth, an ocean above all things; none of them surrounds Him. He is the highest similitude — which is to say, the proof of the One who has nothing like Him. He did not say that there is nothing like Him, because indeed there is nothing like Him; He meant that there is no evidence for Him like that evidence

— He has the highest similitude — no proof like His proof among any other evidence from those of His creation who have described Him to us. May Allah bless the Lord of the Great Throne.

The boy fell quiet, then said: the meaning has grown great, and the scope has widened. Is the air, then, something that stands between God and the greatness you have described in it?

Yes, the scholar said.

What is it?

It is time.

And what is time?

It is the time of the will by which He created what He willed, and commanded what He wished.

6. Outer and Inner, Body and Soul

The boy lifted his eyes and said: you have brought me to the shores of the seas of the Most High. Return me now to the sciences of this world and the things that resemble them, so that I may use them in my own affairs and grow stronger by them to bear what I am meant to bear. I feared for myself, and I felt sorry for my mind, that it might wander into a country it cannot survive.

I told him: you have risen above your own question, and you have done well to feel that fear. The outward meaning by itself is already enough to set your opinion and your mind reeling — what would it be if I drew back the curtain on an inner meaning? You and I would be like Moses

and al-Khidr walking the shore together, the one shocked by what the other knows.

He said: is there, beyond this inner, another inner more subtle still?

I said: by my life, the inner is the highest of all dwellings. It is greater in power and more complete than the outward, for it is the ultimate guide along the road of salvation.

He said: then I see three layers of knowledge here — the apparent, the inner, and the inner of the inner. Is there a proof of this?

I said: where else would the evidence be except in this very thing, and in what it points to?

He said: then show me these three layers.

I said: I will teach you from the Book of God and from the argument of the intellect. This is what the audience of parables points toward.

He said: I did not imagine there was any doctrine beyond what I had already reached. If only I had commanded — God is the greatest of all things, before whom the illusions of the arrogant are humbled and exalted.

I said: as for the Book of God, He has said:

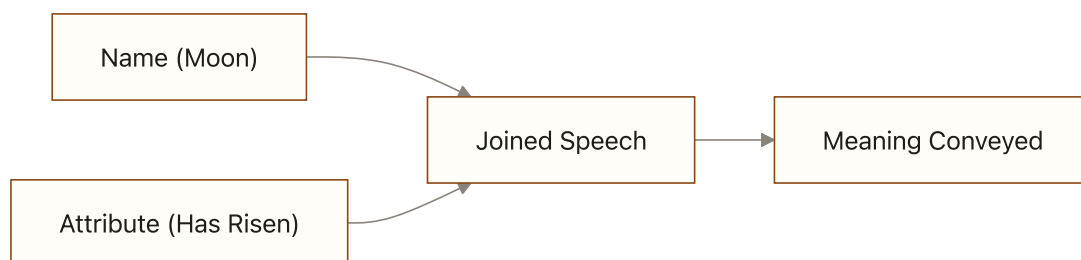
يَا بَنِي آدَمَ قَدْ أَنْزَلْنَا عَلَيْكُمْ لِبَاسًا يُؤَارِي سَوَاتِكُمْ وَرِيشًا وَلِبَاسُ التَّقْوَىٰ ذَٰلِكَ خَيْرٌ

"O children of Adam, We have sent down to you a garment that covers your private parts, and feathers for adornment; and the garment of piety — that is best."

That is three: the outward, the inward, and the inward of the inward.

He said: I am convinced.

I said: as for the argument of the intellect — nothing is known except by a name, an attribute, or a meaning. The meaning is what the thing is. The name is what it is called. The attribute is what guides toward it. In just the same way, the religion of God has outward names and inward proofs, and neither can be fulfilled except by the other. It is indicated only by a noun or an attribute — as when someone says, "The moon has risen." The meaning is the disk in the sky; "moon" is its name; "has risen" is its attribute. If he says "has risen" and falls silent, nothing has been conveyed. If he says "moon" and falls silent, nothing has been conveyed either. Only when the name and the attribute are joined, and he says "the moon has risen," is the meaning clear and the speech sound.



Shows how name and attribute must join to convey meaning, illustrated by the moon example.

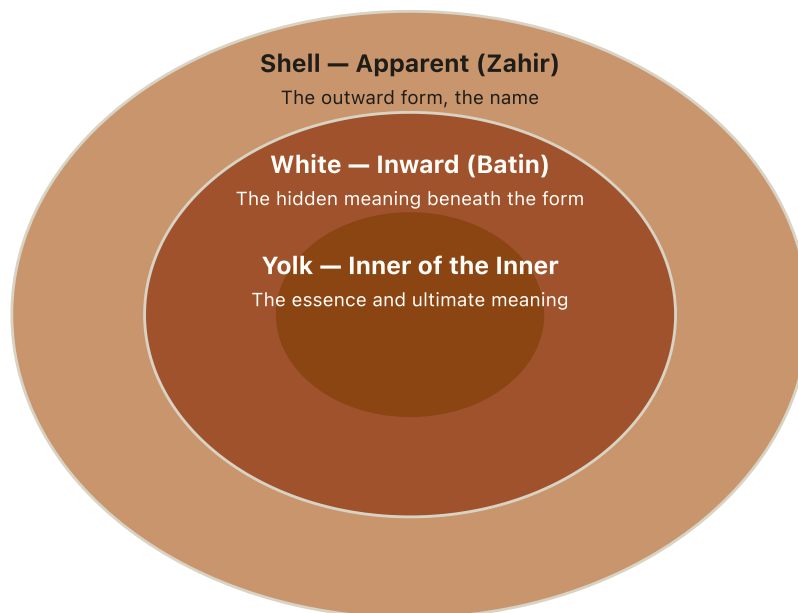
So too, if you say "apparent," you must say "the apparent of what?" If you say "inward," an answer is owed: "the inward of what?" But if you say, "the apparent of the religion and its inward," the words are understood, and both together become its religion — its apparent and its inward. As for the thing that has the name of an attribute, He said:

وَذَرُوا ظَاهِرَ الْإِثْمِ وَبَاطِنَهُ

"And give up the appearance of iniquity and its interior."

So sin itself became a thing with an outward and an inward. So too is the religion of God, the Greatest. The one who says "the laws" speaks of a thing whose outward is outward, and whose inward is inward — each existing on its own. And knowledge itself: its meaning has many parables that point to it, such as the hidden egg, which has an outward — the shell; an inward — the white within; and an inner of the inner — the yolk, which is its essence and its meaning.

Three Layers of Knowledge (Egg Parable)



Shows the three nested layers of knowledge — outward, inward, and inner of the inner — through the egg parable.

He said: are not this world and the Hereafter a pair, and the soul and the body a pair, and the knowledge of the apparent and of the subtle a pair,

and so on — many pairs, all of them?

I said: I accept that. But are they pairs of a single kind?

He said: the pairs all point to the religion of God.

I said: I accept that as well. The pair is this: the outward is a name, and the inward is an attribute, and what they signify together is the knowledge of God and the religion of God — which is the inner. So too is the creation of the three houses of worship: first the creation of the angels, second the creation of human beings, and third the creation of the beasts. The apparent is the knowledge of the limit of beasts; whoever knows only that, without the secret, is like the beasts. The knowledge of the inward is the knowledge of the children of Adam alone; whoever knows it is a believer, like a true human being. The knowledge of the inner of the inner is the knowledge of the angels; whoever knows it has become the spiritual counterpart of the physical knowledge of the body, and he is a prophet sent by God in His land, by whom He argues against His creation. He is the veil of the angels, the symbol of revelation and its interpreter for the children of Adam. With him are the keys of Paradise, which only those who obey him will enter; and with him is the permission for the fire, which none enter except by his staff.

Three Houses of Creation and Their Knowledge

Each rank of being corresponds to a depth of knowledge

Order of Creation	Knowledge & Human Type
Angels	Inner of the inner — Prophet
Children of Adam	Inward — Believer
Beasts	Apparent only — Beast-like

Maps each layer of knowledge to its corresponding order of creation and the human type it produces.

The people are only two men. One has been taught the purpose of knowledge, whose soul has been animated by the spirit of certainty — a scholar by his knowledge and a master by his work. The other is a learner, still seeking, working for his own survival. The rest of the people are savages and a rabble who know nothing. The followers of every false guide have been deceived by his error and seduced by his ignorance; they imagine they are doing well, but they have been deprived of the true examples, and they will not be left behind by what God has promised them — and the disbelievers will have the like of it.

He said: so this is what virtue is, and this is how knowledge and its exposition unfold. Blessed are the guardians of God, and blessed are the followers of benevolence. Will I attain to this great station — the example of houses above all houses?

I said: O my son, this is a station God has honored above every house and every degree, and you will only attain it by virtuous work. If the soul does its work, and you seek it with honest certainty and a clear,

conscious heart, I have hope that you will realize from it what the saints of God, the righteous, have realized.

He said: and who can aspire to attain the likeness of a station to which God raises His guardians?

I said: their God is your God, and between God and anyone else there is closeness only through meeting Him and doing good deeds. The knowledge by which God has raised His guardians — you are at its beginning, and if you act on it, you will reach its end. God is bound to inform you of the totalities given to the righteous among them, and He will not deprive you of anything He gave them.

He said: can you help me toward that? Was it not granted to you first?

I said: this is a place where nothing avails except the work of its own people.

He said: how, then, can you help in it at all?

I said: the sower can prepare the land, sow the seed, and water it — but he cannot bring out the plant or the leaves. A man can be a craftsman whenever he wills — but he cannot create from his work whatever he wills. So do not reproach me, my son, that you seek my help in a thing in which I do not yet see you fully established. May God expand your chest and illuminate your heart with guidance. Fear God and do what is best, for God does not waste the reward of the best of deeds. You are already on the path of salvation, the path of guidance, the path of the people of piety — your path, the one you are already walking. Hold fast to the rope to which you have been called, until you are guided by a rope from God to the rope of God, for that is the goal of the seekers.

He said: is it not the rope of God to which you have called me?

I said: it is the rope made apparent to you. It is your rope and your most trustworthy link, your *hujja* — your argument — and the door of your Imam.

He said: then what is the rope of God itself, and what is the rope of the rope of God?

I said: that is the end of your guidance and the end of all the worlds.

He said: there is no power except in God. The one who has no proof has drowned in the depths of ignorance, just as the one who has no ship has drowned in the seas of the world.

I said: and what is this power I have mentioned, which they cannot possess except by God?

He said: we say, *لَا أَمْلِكُ لِنَفْسِي نَفْعًا وَلَا دَفْعَ مَا أَكْرَهُ إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ* — "It is not for me to bring any benefit to myself, and I have no power to repel what I hate, except by God."

I said: why is it that you say,

لَا حَوْلَ وَلَا قُوَّةَ إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"There is no power and no strength except in God,"

and you do not say "there is no stratagem except in God"?

He said: in our sciences we have it that *hawl* is the same *hawl* as in God's saying *hawlayni kamilayni* — "two complete years." It means a year. And the public has shown us that *quwwa* — power — means mules, because God says:

وَأَتَيْنَاهُ مِنَ الْكُنُوزِ مَا إِنَّ مَفَاتِحَهُ لَتَنُوءُ بِالْعُصْبَةِ أُولِي الْقُوَّةِ

"And We gave him such treasures, the very keys of which would weigh down a band of strong men."

They said: the *usba* is forty men, and the *quwwa* is the mules. The keys to his treasures filled forty mules.

I said: so by your words "there is no power except in God," do you mean there is no year and no mule except by God? Is that really the interpretation of your saying and its meaning?

He said: I have no other opinion than this. It is for the weak and the lowly. It resembles something from the words of wisdom, and I do not think the meaning is anything else — for this is stronger in speech and more powerful in the play of imagination. Do they have some inner interpretation of it other than this?

I said: creation has not uttered any true word except that it has an origin in the subtle, and there is no false word except that it has a meaning. So I return speech to its meaning. Its meaning is that the impossible becomes impossible, and whoever has departed from his proper position has changed — yet the truth, if it is not false, is rather a speech by which a person perceives what follows by analogy and by form, just as he perceives what is in front of him by likeness and parable.

He said: I am convinced. So what is the meaning of these two words, and others like them?

I said: as for *al-hawl* — he is the Imam of God and His truthful caliph, the lord of the twelve captains, just as the *hawl* (the year) is completed only in twelve months. The Imam is called *hawl* because he *yuhawwil* — he

converts, he turns — the words of the Creator gently into the words of human beings, until they are understood. They then become apparent speech, and the words of wisdom acquire a body, while the words of the Creator carry within them the spirit of life and the light of salvation. The excellence of the words of wisdom over every other speech is the excellence of the words of the Creator that lie within them. The Imam is called *al-hawl* because of this converting of words, and he does not change them except by the permission of God.

And *quwwa* — power — is his *hujja* and his door, whom God has strengthened to bear the heavy burden of utterance. He takes the speech from the Imam as a whole, and distributes it among the *da'is*, the preachers, in detail, according to their houses. So the *hujja* is called *quwwa*, because he is strengthened only by God. Whoever says "there is no power except in God" means: there is no Imam and no *hujja* except by God, and from God comes their light and their sustenance.

As for the *usba*, the band, it is the first power — they are the ten arguments. Joseph too said to his father:

يَا أَبَتِ إِنِّي رَأَيْتُ أَحَدَ عَشَرَ كَوْكَبًا وَالشَّمْسَ وَالْقَمَرَ رَأَيْتُهُمْ لِي سَاجِدِينَ

"O my father, I saw eleven planets, and the sun and the moon — I saw them prostrating themselves to me."

By the sun he meant the Imam, by the moon his *hujja* and his door, and by the planets the twelve captains. Likewise Joseph's brothers said:

لْيُؤْسِفُ وَأَخُوهُ أَحَبُّ إِلَيَّ أَيْنَا مِنَّا وَنَحْنُ عُصْبَةٌ

"Truly Joseph and his brother are dearer to our father than we are, though we are a band."

By "band" they meant the twelve captains — *let him choose a man from among us*. Within them lay the lack of right opinion in the matter of Joseph, peace be upon him. One of them showed envy toward him when God favored him. Yet the command of God was fulfilled in Joseph, and the outcome of their plot was remorse and repentance before him.

He said: praise be to God, who cleansed them of their impurity and returned them to obedience. What is the meaning of the king's saying — *I see seven fat cows being eaten by seven lean ones, and seven green ears of grain and others dry?* What are they? And what is a dream-vision itself?

I said: as for the dream-vision, it is like outward work — like a mirage one comes upon and finds nothing. So too is the work of the outward without the inward: nothing of it is accepted of him, however much there is. Likewise the vision in a dream is not realized from what one sees, even if one sees it many times.

The king's saying "I see," in the people's account, refers to seven things turning upon seven. The seven fat cows are the causes of God between Him and His creation. The seven lean ones are the seven appointed speakers, the *natiqs*, who seek what comes from God through His seven causes. The seven green ears are al-Khidr — a cause between God and the *awliya*, the guardians. The seven dry ones are the guardians, obliged to receive from God at the hands of these seven causes. So blessed be God, Lord of the worlds.

He said: and what is the like of this among us?

I said: this is the foundation of Islam. Its child is like a grain that sprouted seven ears — meaning that seven or eight imams came out of his loins.

He said: how can God forbid this world and say,

وَلَا تَغُرَّتْكُمْ الْحَيَاةُ الدُّنْيَا

"Be not tempted by the life of this world"?

I said: God has spoken truly. He did not say that the world should not tempt you. He said: *be not tempted by the life of this world*. Life has four meanings. There is a life apparent in this world, whose consequence is annihilation, and there is the life of the Hereafter, whose consequence is permanence. He is saying: do not work for a perishing life — work for the lasting life. This is His saying,

يَا لَيْتَنِي قَدَّمْتُ لِحَيَاتِي

"Oh, would that I had sent forward something for my life,"

meaning, would that one had sent forward, in the perishing life, something for the lasting life.

And the two lives in another sense: a life of outward knowledge, and a life of inward knowledge. The knowledge of the outward is the life of this world — and that is the lower knowledge — and the knowledge of the inward is the life of the Hereafter. This is why He said, *Be not tempted by the life of this world* — meaning, do not let yourself be tempted by the outward of knowledge and the acting on it alone. He will only accept

from you the inward together with the outward; He does not accept the outward without the inward.

He said: and what of one who knows the inward knowledge but does not know the outward, and does not act on it — what is his standing among the people of religion?

I said: he is at the level of the prophet — but if his inward does not rise up, neither does his outward rise. There may be something good in him; but if he abandons something he was commanded to do, and lets his inward stand alone like the outward of fruits — for if the rind is peeled off the fruit before it is harvested, the fruit is spoiled and cannot be repaired afterward; and if the body is severed, the soul cannot be sustained in it for an hour — then he is in the same case. So religion: if its obligations are disrupted, they cannot be restored to their owner. Even so, his leaving the outward without the permission of the One who imposed it on him cannot escape one of two characteristics. Either he abandoned it from incapacity — and if he was incapable, he was so to the One who commanded him — or he abandoned it in disobedience. The disobedient is a sinner, and the disobedient is not near to the guardians of God; rather he is their enemy, and they are his enemies, because he severs what God commanded him to keep joined.

He said: and what of one who knows the outward knowledge and acts on it, but does not know the inward — what is his standing among the people of religion?

I said: an evil standing. He is like a body that has been raised up but into which no soul has been breathed. He is counted among the dead, and the dead are the abodes of the disbelievers. Like one who disbelieves in the signs of God, he is an enemy of religion and of its people.

He said: I see now that the outward is not valid except by the inward, and the inward is not made good except by the outward; that the world is not lawful except for those who know the Hereafter, which is its true life and its inward; and likewise, religion is not granted to its people unless they establish both its outward and its inward.

I said: yes — this is the meaning, and this is the work. The fulfilment of all that God has commanded is what is worthy of His pleasure, and the abandonment of any of what God commanded exposes one to His displeasure.

He said: then whoever knows the outward together with the inward, and establishes them both — is he a true believer?

I said: yes. He is a true believer.

He said: is there not also one who learns and then works for the Hereafter, and along with that takes the world and its good and what swings to him of its gains?

I said: yes — and the world is not made good except for them. They are the most righteous in this world and its foremost people.

He said: but I do not see the people of this character — the ones who are the scholars among the people — except that these things of the world and what is in it have been pushed away from them, until the ignorant among them suppose that the world is forbidden to them. They are remote from this world; they see of it only a portion, and their souls find it heavy. Their colors have yellowed without obvious cause, their bodies are weak, their skins cling to their bones; they do not eat their food even while they are eating it.

When I heard him mention my brethren and describe them so, I beamed, and my eyes overflowed with tears; at moments I could not speak from

the intensity of the lesson. The boy wept at my weeping, until I feared some of our enemies might catch wind of us. I took hold of myself and my heart settled within me, and I turned back to him.

I said: O my son, the people you have described in this way looked upon themselves by the light of life and worked in their affairs with the certainty of salvation, and they did not grow arrogant over themselves. O my son, this world is seen by the eye of wealth and children, and the Hereafter is seen by the eye of knowledge and certainty. O my son, these people's faith in the unseen is sound; they believed the promise and the warning, and they were satisfied; they were terrified by the fear of the threat, so they laboured; they feared the drunkenness of death, so they hastened to good deeds. Their bodies were weakened by the rigor of fasting, and their colors yellowed by the length of their vigils. They do not sleep when the sleepers sleep, out of fear, nor do they eat of sustenance more than a morsel. The pleasure of pondering desires has been inspired in them, and the sweetness of remembrance has distracted them from the appointed hour of sleep. The desires of this world's spectacle have been emptied out of them; they remember death often, so that life does not torment them; they have seen the Hereafter as certain, and they have seen this world only as a fragment. So they refused to work the world, even from what is not forbidden to them.

He said: this is the true news. In this sense the scholars hated this world; and the people were heedless of them, supposing they had forbidden to themselves what God had made lawful for them. You have described to me the arrogance of the people of the world in their bodies, and their heedlessness of the Hereafter.

I said: if people would only think about the world, their states would change — from weakness to strength, and from strength back to weakness, from bliss to demise, and from life to death. They would then

look at those who passed before them, the vanished centuries: the good and the wicked went down to the same level. They did not see a reward for the good in this world, nor a punishment for the wicked in this world — so they would have known that they had been created for something other than this world. But the world weighed on them, and they did not bear upon themselves the provisions of what was being asked of them. So they took this paltry portion as a substitute, and they were satisfied with the bliss of this world in place of the Hereafter. This is their effort, and this is their meaning; they have no argument before God, and no propriety toward His guardians, when the news has already reached them of what is dreadful.

He said: praise be to God, who has guided us to His religion — and we could not have been guided except by His favor. Tell me about the beginning of this creation and their composition: is it a single creation, or different? And why do I see so much difference in opinions and in passions?

I said: as for the creation of bodies, it is different, as you see, in the variety of tongues and colors — and that is a proof of God's power, made clear by the signs, so that the created among them can know one another: the child knows his father and the father knows his son; the man knows his wife and no other woman, and the woman knows her husband and no other man — just as God created them. But as for the creation of the instrument — namely the senses, what is apparent of them and what is hidden — it is a single creation, and what is hidden inwardly will tell you the same. Have you ever seen a scholar with three eyes as an increase in him, or an ignorant man with one eye as a deficiency in him, so that one might say the scholar saw by way of increase and the ignorant failed to see by way of decrease? Have you seen any increase in the instrument of one over another? No — you see their

creation only as a single, level creation in the apparent instrument, and the meaning of the composition is the same. So we have come to know that the inner senses follow this same example. It is justice. God would not have been just in what is apparent and unjust in what is hidden, nor would He have made for the scholar two hearts in one cavity, nor deprived the ignorant of anything. The instrument is one, and the composition belongs to the One who gathers it. Thus God has argued against them by the very instrument He has made for them, which they did not use. The Almighty said:

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ آذَانٌ لَا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا

"They have hearts wherewith they do not understand, and they have eyes wherewith they do not see, and they have ears wherewith they do not hear."

Are they unable to bear it, or its burden? No — He is fairer than that.

He said: I do not see it otherwise, and I do not say it. But I am asking you about the difference of passions. Where did they come from, when the instrument is whole and the origin of the composition is the same?

I said: as for the origin, it is one. All of them are from Adam, and Adam is from dust, created by his Lord, who breathed into him of His Spirit. But they deviated from the *sunna* by marriage: they were born on a non-religious basis and grew up upon another way. And I do not doubt that among them are children of adulterers who call upon fathers who are not their own. When the origins were corrupted, the branches were corrupted with them; the way back was lost to them, and it became difficult for them to return to the truth — with their arrogance in

obedience, their laziness in worship, and their envy of the guardians of God — so they no longer held to the limit of the lawful and the forbidden.

He said: if the origin is the same and the instrument is the same, where, then, does the difference of passions come from, when their meaning in seeking is the same — for everyone seeks the good for himself?

I said: by my life — their meaning in seeking is one, but they differ in hitting the mark, like archers aiming at a target. They are unanimous in shooting at it with courage and with the instrument, and they differ only in striking it. So too, the hearts in the breasts and the minds are united, and the minds are united in safeguarding and in securing the dignity of the body. When the call of truth appeared, they differed. Some of them held that answering the Messengers and humbling themselves before them was part of one's dignity toward oneself and the protection of it from folly. Others held that denying them and lifting himself above their obedience was a part of his dignity toward himself and his protection of it from the narrowness of worship. The origin was the same: to seek ease for the body and dignity for the soul. So some of them chose what the Messengers promised them of the reward of God — even if it cost them, in this world, what was dear to behold — because of its permanence. Others chose from the bliss of this world, even though it perishes, because of its presentness, the ease of its asking, and the swiftness of its reward. The very hearts by which the first sought the bliss of the Hereafter, by these the second sought the bliss of this world. Each looks at himself, and each supposes himself an adviser to himself. So they came together in the seeking and differed in the striking. This is the justice of God, His generosity, and the extending of His giving: each seeker is given what he sought; whoever sought the reward of this world

is given from it, and whoever sought the reward of the Hereafter is given from it.

He said: the people of this world have classes within this world: some are wealthy in business, kings of abundant wealth; some are poor in money, serving them to receive from them. Then the bliss of this world brings them together on one side. Are they all alike in evil consequences, or is it for some of them and not the others?

I said: it is of the justice of God that He joins them to one another and does not separate them in their forsaking of Him and in their affection for one another. They are equal in His punishment, just as they were, in His disobedience, joined together.

7. Wealth, Zakat, and the Naming

So we had come, the boy and I, to the edge of a question that the boy himself, with that quickness of his, would not let rest. Classes in this world, degrees in the next — if God had joined the wealthy and the serving poor on a single side in their forsaking of Him, what then of religion itself? Did the same logic hold? The boy asked it plainly.

"This religion which God has honored and perfected, accepting it as a religion for Him and imposing it upon His servants — will He accept it from some without the others, so that they will be in their classes like the people of this world? Or will only those who bring it in full be accepted from?"

I told him: if the people of this world have classes within this world, then the people of religion have degrees within their religion. Justice requires it. The Creator is to be worshipped to the measure of His will, the magnitude of His sovereignty, and the magnitude of His servants need of

Him — and His mercy expanded toward them. He knew there were weak ones among them, so He accepted from them what was easy of striving, in work and in obedience, whether little or much. Then He charged the whole of His creation according to its capacity and according to its work, and every soul upon whom His bounty has flowed stands at a degree with its Lord. He made worship the way. He said:

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ
وَالصَّدِّيقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ ۖ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ۚ ذَٰلِكَ الْفَضْلُ مِنَ
اللَّهِ

"And whoever obeys Allah and His Messenger — those will be with the ones upon whom Allah has bestowed favor: the prophets, the truthful, the martyrs, and the righteous. What excellent companions they are! That is the bounty from Allah."

This bounty, I told him, is reached by exerting effort in obedience — not strictly by the merit of the deeds themselves. The righteous attain that rank only as a mercy from God to them, even when they themselves are weak and their works are slight.

The boy said: "Praise be to God, who has done this for them. Then is it to be feared that anyone should be punished for something other than disobedience, even when his work is little?"

I said: "God is more just than that."

He pressed: "Is it possible, then, for anyone to enter Paradise without works — such as the insane, and small children?"

"That falls under the grace of God," I said, "His generosity, and the breadth of His mercy."

He kept walking toward the thing he wanted. "What, then, is the limit of effort in obedience, and the standard of sincere work, such that God is bound to accept one's excuse in all else?"

"The full measure of one's knowledge," I told him, "and the utmost reach of one's capacity."

Then he asked the question that holds inside it the whole of what comes after. "Describe to me the duty of knowledge and the duty of action, and the goal of each, so that I may test myself. If I am able to reach the goal in seeking the pleasure of my Lord, I shall press on; otherwise I shall stop at the limit of my capacity, since God is the first to excuse me for what I cannot do. And I do not trust my own soul. God is just, and I am safe from injustice on His part — but I am afraid of the evil within myself."

I said to him: "Do not fear where you have come to believe, and do not feel secure where you should still fear. Strive for the sake of God with both your person and your wealth. For God does not accept what He hates, nor does He hate what pleases Him. He hates ingratitude in His creation, and He is pleased when His servants give thanks and act with justice in His judgment. He accepts only from those who come to Him with truthfulness and faithfulness — these are the gardens of His Paradise — so that only the people of truthfulness and faithfulness are saved."

"Then show me the goal of my work," he said, "and what God has made binding upon me in it."

I said: "Obedience to God ennoble its people, even when their origins are humble; and good work is the crown of those who do it. What is incumbent upon you in your own person is to perform every obligation and to avoid every forbidden thing — for this is the very religion of your soul and the purification of your body. And the sum of what is obligatory upon you, that God may be pleased with you and accept you, is this: extend to others what you would wish extended to yourself, and refrain from doing to others what you would wish refrained from being done to you. This is justice — and God is pleased with justice."

"Yes," he said, "this is the binding truth, and whoever does not act by it has nothing with God. Then is there any further latitude beyond what you have mentioned?"

"God has made things easy for His servants," I said, "out of His compassion and mercy. He has said:

فَمَنْ اضْطُرَّ غَيْرَ بَاغٍ وَلَا عَادٍ فَلَا إِثْمَ عَلَيْهِ

Whoever is compelled — without willful transgression — there is no sin upon him."

"Praise be to God," he said, "who has not made religion a hardship for His servants. I am resolved to hold fast to what He has commanded, and I seek His help in doing as He has ordered me. But what of my wealth? You joined wealth to my own person when you said I must act with your person and your wealth."

Now we had come to it. I told him: "Your wealth is whatever God has granted you of every kind of gain. Take it only from a lawful source, and spend it only in its rightful place."

"And what is the rightful claim by which it is taken, and in what place is it to be spent?"

"Its lawful source," I said, "is acquisition in which you have wronged no one and which you have not mixed with falsehood. As for the rightful claim upon it, that is its zakat. Look at all that has come into your possession, whether little or much, and take from it a fifth of the best of it — what you yourself would love to receive — and pay it to those who have a binding claim upon you. In this way wealth gives its alms, just as your body gives its alms through work. Work is the gateway to Paradise, and zakat is purification, and whoever pays the zakat has succeeded."

"I shall do so," the boy said, "and I repent to God for what has passed. Then what shall I do with the remainder of my wealth?"

"You shall spend upon yourself and your family with kindness. And if your bounty exceeds your need, single out the poor among your brethren and extend your favor to all who are willing to receive it — for one who has no merit of his own needs the favor of another. Hasten to every good and rush ahead to every act of bounty, for this is the goal of work, if only you are patient in it."

"Yes," he said, "patience, and then more patience. And how can a great man fail to be patient in the face of the poverty of those who cannot do without his help? Every needy one practises patience, and every one who has been favored should give thanks."

I was pleased — I will admit it to you, reader — and the pleasure of that moment is still with me. "Praise be to God," I said, "who has guided you to speak rightly. I ask Him to help you bring the work to completion, for that is the perfection of virtue."

And then the boy said what I had been waiting, without knowing it, to hear.

"I had been asking another for the credit of a favor I should have done for myself; and when at last that credit fell to me, I deprived myself of it, finding no one able to cheat me out of it on my own behalf. All this wealth lies in your hands now, in five shares. One share is its zakat. One share is the expiation for what I have wasted. One share is thanksgiving to God for what I have come to know. One share for the poor among my brethren. And one share that you accept by your grace — and it will return to you increased. Join every one of them to yourself, and God will repay you in their kind."

The narrator says: my heart was moved on the boy's behalf when I saw how the jewel within him had revealed itself, and how the ordeal had brought forth a praiseworthy result, and that the boy had truly made his bounty and his zakat his work. The tears came, and I let them come.

"O my son," I said, "may scholars travel the road for the sake of one like you. May the earth rise and the heavens remain stable for the sake of one like you. May the bonds of kinship be made manifest, and the rain come down from the bellies of the clouds, for the sake of one like you. So here — build with what God has given you and with the breast He has opened to Islam. Take the glad tidings of a light from your Lord and a swift opening, and accept God's gift to you and the gains of gratitude that come with great work and noble thanksgiving.

"As for my share of this wealth — I have no need of it. I have come out from wealth and from its temptations, fleeing from it. It would not be right, my son, that you should return me to what I have detested. As for your brothers share, that you will keep for them: they will turn to you for the things you have done for them by your own hand, so that they may

know your kindness and thank Him for your benevolence. As for the share of expiation, I will show you how to use it, so you may know your duty. As for the share of thanksgiving — that is a trust kept for God until you understand what you do not yet know and rise to a goal beyond your present sight. As for the share of zakat, that too is a trust held for the rightful owner of zakat — every one of them is your concern until he receives what is his, for God is the Ruler over you and on your behalf."

The boy looked at me. "Who is this generous one among you, who does not overreach his own judgment and does not transgress his own command?"

I said: "He is the one whose right God has made binding upon me and upon every believer, in whose hand are the keys of the heavens and the landmarks of the kingdom, whose palms are opened with the light of Sinai. He is the cause behind the signs, and the one whose knowledge calls to the loftiest of ends. Through him your light is completed, through him God perfects your affair, and at his hand you are blessed."

"Such kindness as this," the boy said, "to whom does it belong — and who are you yourself?"

"I am his son," I said, "and one of his servants in good works, seeking his pleasure and shunning his displeasure."

"I think I am far from his good pleasure," the boy said, "and yet close enough that — had I not known of him — I would have an excuse. Do I have an excuse, given what I now know?"

"An excuse," I said, "is granted only before exposure to such knowledge."

"Shall I speak, or shall I hold back?"

"Say what seems best to you."

"Should you not, at this moment, take me by the hand to the door of his chamber until I enter, and to the house of light until I draw from it? This is part of the full measure of truthfulness which is binding upon you."

"This is your duty," I said. "But only with his permission and his decision."

The narrator says: I took my leave then and departed. The boy wished to press more upon me, but he thought better of forcing it. He went on, and his father came to him, and I described the boy to him and assured him that the boy was now of the company of the people of goodness and of the lineage of truthfulness. The father marvelled at it.

"Make haste with this boy," he said, "for I hope that he will be a door of mercy that God opens for the people of his age."

I lingered only a little, and then came back to the boy — and found him in a different state of body than the one I had left him in.

"What is this I see in you," I said, "different from the state in which I left you?"

"And what is it that you have noticed in me — may my father and mother be your ransom?"

"Weakness of body, and yellowness of color."

"That is from a trial that befell me after your departure."

"What is this trial, and what is the cause of this weakness?"

"Your absence grieved me, and fear of two events before meeting you again weakened me."

"God has known what is in your heart," I said, "and so has made the affliction easy. I cast mercy upon you into the heart of the one who has

charge of you. So take up your traveling provisions, for I have high hopes for you, and I will accompany you to the door of your goal — and there is no power except by God."

The narrator says: at this the boy was so overcome by joy and reverence that his soul almost left his body, until God took hold of him, knowing his condition; then He returned him, and when the boy revived, he said: "Praise be to God, who has not yet withdrawn from believers the mercy of compassion."

And he gave great thanks to his father, and came up to his palms to kiss them in service. He rose at once, took the traveling kit, and we set out until we reached the greater scholar — my own teacher, the master. We sought permission and were admitted; we entered, gave our greetings, and sat down with his permission. When we were settled in the council, the boy turned to me and said: "Teach me how to speak, and how to ask for what I need."

I said to him: "It is not for me to instruct you in this place. Out of respect for the master of this house, you are in the hands of one who knows your need and knows what you will."

So I held the boy's hand, and we stayed with the master for some time, until the boy had completed his guidance and reached the end of his hope — and came to know what he had and what was required of him. Then he prayed and went out.

We both withdrew. We had spoken no words in the council save those of peace and well-being; the boy had turned yellow from the intensity of his awe and could not speak. The master, the lord of the house, ordered that we be honored and that whatever we needed be done. He then went on with us to his house, and when he had brought us in he greeted us and showed his pleasure in us.

The master said to me — and between us was brotherhood and an old companionship in learning — "Brother, is this the boy we used to hear about?"

"Yes," I said, "the one whose remembrance is sweet in the hearts of the believers."

The boy said: "Has the report of my story really reached the saints of God, until they study it in their gatherings of remembrance?"

"Yes, my brother," I said, "that is how it is."

"You have surrounded me from every side," he said, "and overtaken me from every direction. I do not know whom to thank, nor whom to repay."

Then we all sat down and conversed through the night. When morning came, we asked permission to enter upon the Shaykh. When we were admitted and had completed our greetings, the Shaykh gave us permission to sit, and we sat. Then the Shaykh began to speak.

"Praise be to God," he said, "who has opened their hearts with His light, and who is pleased by His justice when He is remembered as He requires, and is pleased that remembrance becomes a kindness to His servants and a mercy from Him to whoever He wills. He has not taken creation as a duty owed to Him, nor has He charged them with what they cannot bear in disbelief of His blessings. Rather, the affair is set in the middle between two extremes — and this is what is called justice. He has spread out His hands with goodness; He has not disappointed one who calls upon Him, nor turned away one who is silent. Indeed, the bounty of the heavens and the gratitude due to the Lord are not reserved to those who have given thanks for them, on account of the multitude of His reward — and there is no withholding from the one who is ungrateful for them, on account of the greatness of His punishment. So He has shielded

His blessings from any sting of denial, and made His proofs against denial fully documented; and He has expanded over what exists, so that the evidence against ingratitude is itself unlimited — known yet not fully describable. He is the most merciful of His creation and the mightiest; the most merciful of His servants and the most all-powerful; the most just in His ruling; the highest, and yet the closest to His people; and the nearest one whom I keep close, banishing illusions. So worship Him and give thanks to Him — to Him you will return."

Then he said: "But beyond that: it belongs to the dignity of minds that they be put to use through inquiry. One of the fruits of inquiry is what genuinely exists, and one of the marks of existence is its sweetness. Every freshwater spring is a drink whose surface is plain but whose depths are veiled; it never tires of the thought that pursues it, and creation never reaches the end of its purpose. Its proper features are its rights, and a right is a duty — and from that it is truly called to fulfill its obligation. Whoever withholds from a right what is due to it has acted unjustly. Is it not the right of thought to pay zakat to the hearts through good manners? And the right of good manners is to seek knowledge; and the right of knowledge is to be acted upon; and the right of action is that it be performed in purity, in obedience to the First; and the right of obedience is that it be perfected in both hardship and ease, in goodness and in trial — and only the patient receive it, and only the truly fortunate receive it."

Then he turned his face toward the boy and said: "O boy, I have honored you as an estranged friend, and I greet you as a visiting guest. So what is your name?"

He said: "Ubayd Allah, son of Abd Allah" — the servant of God, son of the servant of God.

The Shaykh said: "That is your description, and your news has already been brought to us."

The boy said: "I am free, son of Abd Allah."

The Shaykh said: "And who freed you from a master, until you became free?"

The boy said: "This world possessed me — and I have handed it back to the One who called it."

The Shaykh said: "I have understood. If this one owns and that one is owned, is it permissible for you to claim otherwise?"

"It is not permissible."

"What, then, is your name?"

And the boy fell silent — puzzled by the answer.

The Shaykh said: "O boy, how can a thing know that which has no name?"

The boy said: "I am newborn to you, and you nurture me."

The Shaykh said: "Then wait until the completion of seven days."

"Why has that been deferred until the completion of seven days?"

"For the dignity of the newborn."

"And if the newborn dies before the completion of the seven days?"

"Nothing harms him. He is named after that."

"Is this the name by which you have named me?"

The Shaykh said: "Would you be like an idol, even though you have been born?"

"How can such a thing be said of it?"

The Shaykh said: "The name belongs to you, and you belong to the name. So it does not appear except within your limit, and it travels with your duration."

So the boy rose and hurried to obey him without looking back, out of good manners. He went out, and his father went out with him, until they returned to their lodging. The owner of the house greeted them.

He said: "What is the state of this brother concerning his need?"

I said to him: "It has been promised. The one awaited is thirsty. And the term is near."

So we remained until the seventh day, and then we sought permission of the Shaykh. When he had granted us leave, he ordered the boy to wash and to put on his purest garments. When the boy attended to that, his heart felt the need to relieve himself on that day — and this was what the Shaykh had commanded him to do, as a sign of the good that was to come after it. When the boy had completed what was commanded, we all went out. The boy went out saying, "The day of Sa'd, and the guardian of Sa'd" — the day of good fortune, and its keeper — repeating it again and again. And nothing drove him to this saying except the abundance of his joy and the intensity of his longing to know what would bring him closer to the pleasure of God.

When we came to the Shaykh, we found that he had taken up the implements of his work. He greeted us with peace, and we returned the greeting. Then he ordered the boy to come down to him, and he brought him near. He began to speak of matters upon which no fancy had ever

descended, which no pen had ever traced, and which had never occurred to the heart of any human being — matters that are not to be mentioned in the assemblies of preachers, and that are not permitted in mosques. These books are among the greatest of His bounties, and are unveiled only to His own people.

And when he had discharged his duty and brought the boy out of his bewilderments — the bewilderments that had led him astray — to the very end of guidance, he explained to him his doctrine and gave him his draught of his Lord. So that the boy removed his ihram by glorifying the sanctities of God, took hold of the rope, circumambulated the ancient House, spent his rites in remembrance, and performed Hajj by the great sign.

8. Returning Home, and the Father's Reckoning

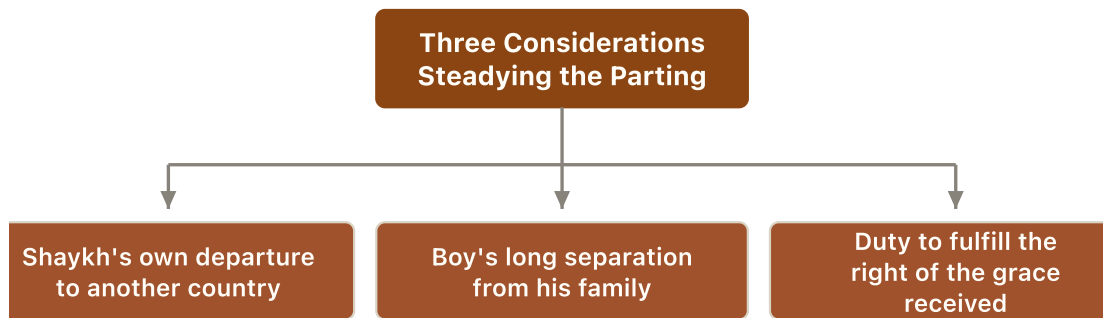
And so the two of them, the boy and his father — by which I mean the father of his spirit, the Shaykh — kept on attending that particular school together. The Shaykh gave, and the boy received, patient and unwearied, never tiring of seeking the man's honor, never turning from one whose answer carried such sweetness on the tongue. They remained in that condition for a long while. The Shaykh watched, and waited, and at last he knew what every true teacher waits to know: that the root had drunk its fill of water, and that the branch had lifted itself toward the sky.

When the boy understood that the season of instruction was drawing to its close, he turned to the Shaykh and spoke in the cadence of one whose gratitude has outrun his vocabulary. "Praise be to God," he said, "who has made you welcome to this station — that through you He revives

religion and brings death to ignorance, and has set you as a stronghold for the people and a refuge for the likes of us. You are the gate of the people of heaven and the ascent of the people of the earth. From the light of your majesty, lights have appeared; from the cup of your palm, rivers have flowed. May you remain so until you are pleased with the One who is pleased with you."

The Shaykh heard this and answered, as a teacher answers when he is about to release the student into the work itself. "And as for you," he said, "may God bless you with what He has given you, help you to preserve what has come to you, and employ you in the fulfilling of His will. May He light your path with the light of His guidance, expand your breast with the keys of wisdom, and ennoble your station with the method of the call — of *da'wa*. May He complete His favor upon you with the modes of response, and grant you such instruction in obedience to Him that you may have the best hope of His good pleasure. I bid you farewell now, my son, and I give you my permission to depart. And as for the weight of this parting — I have resorted to three considerations, that they might steady me in it. The first is that we ourselves are traveling now to another country. The second is your own separation from your family for all this time, with that fear you carried of having gone out without your father's permission, for there is great grief in him, and great anger, and nothing will lift it but your return — and though I am vexed with your father, you must be kind to him. The third is the duty of fulfilling the right of this grace that has reached you, for it is incumbent upon you now to worship by it, and to call others to it."

The Shaykh's Three Consolations at Parting

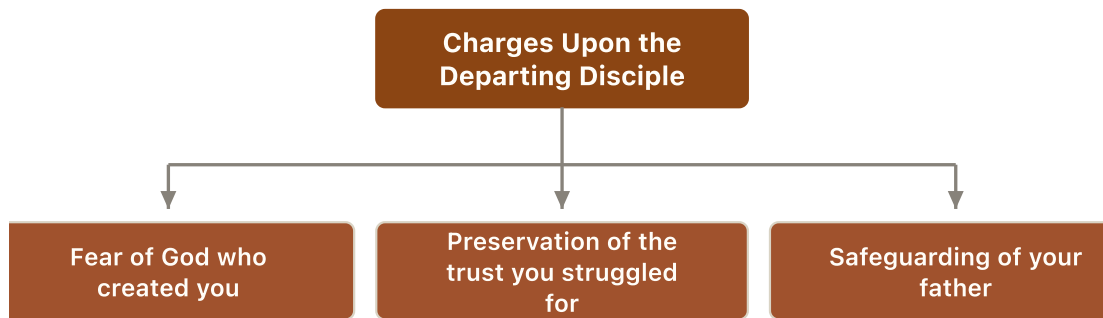


Shows the three considerations the Shaykh names to steady himself at parting.

The boy answered him from a place beneath the words. "Your parting is sorrow to me," he said, "and your loss is a deprivation. But your counsel is more rightly guided than my grief, your obedience more binding upon me, your judgment more sound. So recommend to me what you see fit, and dismiss me when you will, and be kind enough to send my father with me back to my country. I will lean upon him. I will act through him. I will entrust to him all my affairs."

"I shall do that," said the Shaykh. And then he charged him as a master charges an apprentice he is at last sending out into the open world. "I enjoin upon you the fear of God who created you. I enjoin upon you the preservation of this trust for which you have struggled. And I enjoin upon you the safeguarding of your father — who raised you young, and toiled long in your affairs, with his own person and with his wealth. Do not clothe him in the garment of contempt. Do not board him on the ships of harm. Do not omit his name. Do not become distracted from his remembrance. Do not deceive him in your own city — for there is a sting at the very outset of such things."

The Shaykh's Three Final Charges



Shows the three charges the Shaykh lays upon the boy as he sends him into the world.

"May God reward you," the boy said, "on behalf of the Master of grace, with every grateful one's thanks. And may He reward you for the long length of your shepherding, where no hand of mine can repay you. I will keep your commandment. Do not cut off my share from the blessing of your supplication."

Then the two of them rose. They shook hands. They embraced. And each said his farewell to his friend, and neither could contain himself against the weight of that parting, until they were able to speak only by gesture — a lifted hand, a turned face, the small gestures by which the body says what the throat has lost the right to. Then they took their separate ways.

The scholar — by which I mean now the lesser teacher, the one entrusted by the Shaykh with the work of bringing the boy back into the world — set out with him toward his home. And when they had drawn near to the boy's city, and the rooftops where his father waited were already visible at the edge of the road, the scholar drew him aside.

"My son," he said, "I have understood the will of the Shaykh, and you have not. All guidance lies in his words. This is your city now. We have come to the very edge of it. Sit with us here, off the road for a moment, for I wish to remind you of some of my concerns, and to recommend to you what you should now do."

When they were seated, the scholar began. "My son, I am aware of your father and of his enmity toward the people of this matter. And I know this together with the fact of your having gone out with me, and your absence from him without his permission and without his trust. I wish to honor your father's view by concealing some of these affairs, so that you may return to him and he may be at ease again and remain with us as a man among us. And I hope — if you are kind to him — that he will be closer to what you want than anyone else. He has been worn down by your absence. His solitude has become frightening to him. Know this, my son: that God has opened to you the least of your aspirations even before you suppose yourself to be a fully grown man — before a long stretch of time has passed. God has been good to you. So now be good to yourself. Honor the one through whom God has honored you. We have thought well of you, and our hope in you has been great. So you must preserve the trust your father entrusted to you, and stand firm in your affair. Piety and devotion are the guardians of your religion and your work. Thanksgiving and patience are an increase to your light. May God open your provisions and grant you good fortune."

Then the scholar set six things before him, as one sets six stones for a man who has been told he must build a wall. "I commend to you six qualities," he said. "Trust in God when you are resolved. Speak with a ruling when you are called upon. Do not grow angry when you are wronged. Do not weary if you are slandered. Whoever responds to you with good, be patient with him. And devote yourself to the best of those

upon whom you call — for God will help you, and God will open the way for you."

The boy listened, and when he answered he answered with the cadence of one who has counted what he has been given and finds himself richer than he can describe. "May God reward you with three goods," he said. "An imam whose argument you have fulfilled and whose trust you have advised. And a dead man whose life I treated with kindness. My heart is full and my wings are light with the joy of the great things you have set before me. I do not know which of your words is the more excellent — the outward, in which you arranged the matter in its sequence, or the inward, in which you expounded its meanings."

"Praise be to God," said the scholar, "who has made His way easy for you, and brought you near to it. As I bid you farewell now, and am drawn away from you — is there anything still in which someone might help you carry a portion of his burden?"

"There are three needs," said the boy. "A need I have already fulfilled. A need I beg for. And a need I ask you to kindly fulfill."

"I have understood your three needs," the scholar said, "and I will answer you about what you have asked. As for the need that has already passed: your life is in knowledge after death — and may God bless you with a life in it, and grant you the best of what you intended. As for the need for which you pray: act upon what you know, accept what He brings, and God will bring it about for you by His mercy. As for the need you ask of me — it was as if you wished for an increase upon what you have already heard."

"There is nothing greater," the boy said, "than your knowing what is within me. So do as you see fit."

"As for my knowing what is in yourself," said the scholar, "only God knows the unseen. But the believer sees by the light of God. As for the increase — I will make it more luminous for you, and I will stop you upon the foundations on which you have been working, so that you may look back upon all those matters whose outward I have set before you and which you have treated as parable. Whatever in it was praiseworthy is like the truth and its people — the virtues of their virtuous, and the witnesses among them that point to them. And whatever was a reprehensible parable, I spent upon the enemies of the truth and its people — their elders and their young and their children — and the evidence within it points to them. These are the foundations of the science that works by them. If she preserves them, she has no need of any others. And I commend to you the fear of God — from whom you have come, and with whom you have done nothing — and the keeping of His covenant, and the fulfillment of the right that He has imposed upon you and upon all His creation."

When he had finished his discourse, when he had informed the boy of his safety and completed his nurture, he looked at him one last time. "My son," he said, "take care of yourself. I have others besides you. And this is the parting between you and me."

I will tell you what happened in the boy at the sound of that word. He gasped at the mention of parting in such a way that he nearly killed himself with the gasping — his spirit nearly took flight, his soul nearly left the body that contained it. Then he stooped, and he kissed the scholar's feet, and he took the dust from them and wiped it upon his own face, the way a man marks himself with what he refuses to let go. Then he said his farewell, and he turned away.

The boy returned to his house, but his heart was absent from him, gone ahead of him into a fear he could not name. He could not answer any

utterance of his own grief — grief over the parting from his elder father, his second father, the father who had been the very cause of the grace that had reached him. He spent his day and his night agitated with sorrow and alarm, until at last his own family and his neighbors became afraid for him.

And then his father came in to him. Angry.

"My son," the man said, "is this the reward of sons to their fathers? I taught you only the best that a child can be taught by a father. You did not deny your own self, nor renounce your beliefs, until the very hour I grew old with this strange man. You drew him in upon me. You crossed over with him in his affair without ever consulting your parents. If what I knew was true — then you have hindered me in my very self, because you concealed the truth from me. And if it is false — then you have disobeyed me in your own ruin, and whatever has reached him has by that same path reached me."

The boy answered him gently. "My father, I have shown you nothing but mercy, and nothing but compassion. You raised me as a mercy from you. You nourished me. You chose me over family and over wealth. I have no need to be so unkind to you in this day of ours that I should make you the object of one of two strands of gratitude that are owed to you."

"What," the father said, "is the difference between the two strands?"

"Either," said the boy, "you allow me to offer you my courtesies and my favors — for I am still your son, the one you raised young, and the one whom you have commanded us to attribute to God. Or you grant me leave to debate with you, and to give you my full confidence — so that I am safe from your indignation, and so that I may draw upon your mind."

The father considered. "As for your courtesy on the outside, while hearts differ within," he said, "that is itself a reproach between me and you. How long can outward agreement stand when its underpinnings differ? I do not want that. As for your debate, and your candor — you have that. So say what seems best to you."

And the boy said: "Have you seen my standing with you, for forty years, to be anything other than one of two strands? Either you are a scholar — and then you have withheld from me the teaching I am owed, and you must not blame me if you have driven me to seek my own salvation through another. Or you are ignorant — and you are excused with me, for ignorance is forgiven — but you needed a man who was a stranger to me. And so I have gone ahead of you to him only because of your age, and the lateness of your birth into this matter, for I have heard his words just as you have heard them, and I have seen what you have seen."

I tell you, the father's heart was torn open by the boy's words. He knew there was no escape from any of these arguments, no door he could close against them, and his eyes overflowed with tears.

"My son," he said at last, "the argument that has been made against me is yours. And you will share a similar fate with me, if you keep your own affairs secret from me. Remember this for me. If what you say is true, I will accept the dignity of it from you for myself. And even if it is false, I have already rejected it for your sake, out of my compassion for you."

So they debated, at intervals. They disclosed things to each other at length, the son to the father and the father to the son, until at last they were guided together onto the right path — acting upon the religion of God, upholding it, holding fast to it, calling others to it, and cooperating in it. And through the two of them, God revived many of His creation. He sent the boy out into the world to preach, with his father's blessing

now upon him, asking others to come to him. The boy returned to those others, and became a cause for their guidance. And God blessed the people of that whole country through these two men, and at their hands. God commanded what He commanded — and slander was disappointed, and went away with nothing in its mouth.

9. Abu Malik and the Trial of the Old Religion

Let me tell you now about another man, and about what was tested in him, because the same religion that revives a household can also be set before strangers — and what they do with it tells you who they are. The boy's name was Salih, and his father was al-Bakhtari. They had been honored among their people, raised above others, granted a high standing because of the excellence of the manners they had acquired. News of them spread through the country, and with that news went news of their religion, until at last it reached a group who still held to the old creed — the religion they had been born to before this stranger came into their land.

Al-Bakhtari had a long-standing influence among these people. He had been a kind of brother to them in their old religion, and they feared that influence would be cut off from them now that he had stepped out of it. So they gathered, troubled, and went to a scholar of their own — a man they called Abu Malik, "the mighty servant." Among them he was known for his pride, the abundance of his rulings, and his learning in their religion; they nicknamed him "the heel of the inks," meaning he was the foot on which their books stood. He was their authority — by his knowledge, by his command of speech, by his discernment of opinions. They came in to him and sat.

"O Abu Malik," they said, "do you not see what the boy has gone over to?"

"Which boy?"

"Salih, son of al-Bakhtari."

"And what has he gone over to?"

"We are telling you. A stranger has come to the country, with a doctrine and a creed he calls people to, and we do not know what it is. The boy went to him and went off with him without his father's permission, and was absent for some time. Then he came back to his father, speaking the stranger's words, calling to what he was calling for. We are told his father has answered him in his opinion and given his garments over to him. We are overwhelmed by what has happened, and we have held back from them for three reasons. First — al-Bakhtari was almost as a slave to us on account of his father, for the brotherhood in religion he had taught us; we fear estrangement after intimacy, and we hate division after brotherhood. Second — if these people are upon the truth, then we have failed to follow them in it and to help them in it. Third — if they have gone astray, then we have failed to push them away from it and to support the truth and its people. You are the head of our religion and one of our standards. We have come to tell you and to consult you, and we will not turn back from your opinion."

Now hear how Abu Malik answered them — because what he said is half the lesson, and what he could not say is the other half.

"Judge gently," he told them. "I have given thought to this account. You know that al-Bakhtari and his son have been among those we counted as people of judgment and piety, that they have rights and virtues over us from of old. You have brought me news, and you have brought me a self

that is no better than yours — but God has made you independent of needing that. This is news that has come upon people, and an argument has been opened to them, and they have followed it and been satisfied with it. We cannot judge them by error and so wrong them. We cannot judge them by guidance and so wrong ourselves by imitating them. Nor can we say they have been deceived and refuted without knowledge of them — they are nobler than that. What we need is to look at this news with a fair eye, with the light of justice, with the steadfastness of the mind. It has been said: he who is steadfast in matters keeps his authority secure, and he who is hasty in his affairs cannot keep his foot from slipping.

"A breach in any other thing admits repair, an exchange of what was corrupted — like a flaw in food, whose harm is easy to remedy and whose cure is near at hand. But a breach in religion is gravely damaging; its flaw cannot be repaired or exchanged for another — like a breach in the very medicine, which does not dismiss its owner and does not leave him to himself. The best provision we have been given is the treasure of hearts and the acquisition of morals, whose fruits are praiseworthy — and among those fruits is the way of judgment. Judgment is the crown of the learned; by it they are raised, through noble resolve, to the highest of glories; their virtues are made plain in every city, along with the honor they earn by the ease of their demand. We have spared ourselves from that bounty of judgment which we have borrowed, and from some of the learning we acquired in the narrow circumstances we were once in. We endured all that for the sake of His bounty, and we seek His help in it. We must not waste it. This is the time of our need for it, and of putting it to use in what has come to us of this matter that has happened among our brothers. There is no good in leaving them and what they are upon without examining it and arguing with them in it — by means of a

judgment of the able, with the two seekers in agreement, free of any doubt and any accusation.

"These people cannot be free of one of three states. Either they are still upon what we know of religion, and what has happened is only an increase among them of literature, hadiths, poetry, abundant words. Or some increase has come to them within the religion we share, and they have rejoiced in it — and knowledge with every believer is a lost thing, and an increase of knowledge is better than its decrease. Or they have been given guidance other than what we have, through the prophecy of a prophet brought to them, calling them to it, whom they have followed clearly. This last is not denied by the command of God; the creation does not reach the end of God's decree in them or of His will in them, even if they strive their utmost. God is at work every day."

كُلَّ يَوْمٍ هُوَ فِي شَأْنٍ

"Every day He is engaged in some affair."

They were stilled. "O Abu Malik," they said, "we came to you with hearts angry against these people, ready to call them unbelievers, refute their opinion, and decide what we should do with their blood and their property. We have found our hearts humbled by what you have said and by your arguing on their behalf and speaking for them."

He answered them — and I want you to mark this answer — "This argument is not for them. The argument is for the truth. Do not betray it in their absence. If you make the truth's argument depend on whether the one arguing for it is present, then I, too, by defending them have been defending you against the lie — and against pelting the unseen with stones we cannot see fall. Otherwise we would be like the tyrants of the

previous nations, who fancied their doctrines in their own judgment and rejoiced in their own knowledge, until they thought they had encompassed all that God had commanded, taught, and intended to create. They said God would not send messengers after their messengers. They did not consider that beyond what they had reached there might be knowledge or doctrine. So they passed judgment that God should cut off His argument against His creation and His vicegerents in His land. They made God's knowledge in His servants, and what He sent down to His prophets and messengers, no more than the sum of their own minds — and anything beyond that was misguidance to them. So they preferred that opinion and went greatly astray. They made light of it by their own rule, did not forbid for God, and killed the prophets of God. I beg you, by God — do not follow the whims of a people who have gone astray before you. People of intellect may listen to whims through every meaning and be deceived by every way — except the way of religion; in its demand there is exemption, and its virtue is not hidden."

They said, "We do not disobey your command, and what you advise is not hidden from us. We will not have obeyed you in our first matter and then disagreed with you at the end. We have pointed to opinion and made our request: if you see fit, take us to these people, so that we may have their doctrine disclosed to us and we may look into it. If it is reasonable, we will follow; if not, we will avoid."

"That is doubt on your part about what you already hold," he said, "and one who doubts knows neither his own right nor what is wrong about another."

"We stand firm on our truth and accuse whatever falsehood there may be of lying."

"That is not how meaning is sought," he said, "nor is there guidance through lying."

"How then is the request to be made, if we are not to deny falsehood and believe the truth?"

"If you already know the truth and accept it, and know falsehood and reject it — then you are not in the number of seekers. You are in the number of those learned in prophecy, guidance, and authority, who rule by revelation over the people of this world."

"We are convinced of the truth we hold and have no doubt of it. We exempt ourselves from the procedure of the request."

"Have you not agreed, then, that they should be granted favor over you in one respect, so they should be credited over you in many? If you will not consent to be in need in the houses of the seekers, you will sit in ignorance in the houses of the seekers."

"How did this come about — in what way have they been preferred over us?"

"They have been preferred over you in their knowledge of what you know, and more in what you do not know. This is what has come to people: if you will not ask them for it, they will ask you for it; and if you will not listen to them, but strive against them — they will be credited over you both by being the first to ask and by their striving. As for refraining from seeking at all, that is utter ignorance, neglect, a defect in the world — for he who knows must teach, and the ignorant must learn."

"O Abu Malik," they said, "you have shut us off from every approach by your argument, and every word you say is right. Now open a door for us, from your opinion, by which we may act."

"Marveling at one's own opinion is blindness, and neglecting to seek is error. There is no shame in the request — but the seeker needs to know the doors of seeking before he can rightly know what he seeks. Whoever seeks the truth without knowing how to seek it is the quicker to deny it. Falsehood has the signs of hypocrisy and the appearance of acceptable opinions; the truth has the signs of calamity and the contradiction of whims. Who, then, refrains from accepting what passion offers, and bears patiently in the face of calamity, except one whose heart is sound?"

"Here a door has opened for us. Show us what this knowledge of seeking is, and what a sound heart is."

"As for the knowledge of seeking — you must know that you are needy. The needy person must humble himself before what he needs. As for the sound heart — it is the heart that does not persist in denying what is said to it, nor in being arrogant about what it already holds. The truth is what unveils itself and shows its own merit; falsehood is what reveals its own nakedness. The sound heart discerns falsehood by its intellect and accepts the truth by acceptance."

"We have been told," they said, "that whoever is in such a position — who does not verify the truth and does not refute falsehood — is ignorant in his action: if he does not know truth, he cannot follow it; nor can he know falsehood, so as to avoid it."

"What you have related," said Abu Malik, "you have believed. But has not such a one gone beyond the limit of liars, and become two ignorant men in one?"

"Yes — he is ignorant with us, not a liar."

"The ignorant man hopes for the good and seeks it. He seeks knowledge for himself, and otherwise the learned seek it for him — because

ignorance is the root condition of creation, and there is no shame in it for one who seeks knowledge on account of his ignorance. Lying, though, is the worst of commodities. The liar is not guided by his lying, and he is never believed in what is recorded against him."

"You have made us believe it," they said. "We have known the defect of lying, and we will not lie ever, until we know it for what it is. And we have come to know the door of the request through reverence for what is sought. Is this reverence and humility before what is sought to be shown after it has shown its right, or before the statement is given?"

"Rather before the statement," he said, "so that you may grasp the statement with reverence."

"If we revere what is sought until it becomes clear what it holds, and then its statement turns out to be misleading — what is the standing of our reverence? Has it not been wasted?"

"No. It was reverence to God and humility before His command, and you will have its reward, even if the one before whom you humbled yourself did not deserve it. The seeker has fulfilled the duty of the request even if he has not fulfilled the duty of the truth — like a man who seeks something from some king, and is able to ask only with reverence. If the king gives him something of what he asked for, the king fulfills his duty of grace and earns the reward of what he gave. If he gives nothing, the petitioner has at least discharged the duty of asking gently, while stinginess obliged the other to withhold. So too with the seeker of knowledge: he must begin with humility, persistence, and patience in adversity, until he has fulfilled the duty of requesting — and then time will bring him what it brings."

"This is the clear truth. Allow us, then, to go out to these people for what you have indicated to us. We will not count what you have commanded

as burdensome."

"I would not have indicated anything to you," he said, "nor put myself to this trouble, were it not for the fear of falling short by turning you away from the path of God. I would have pointed you on and gone ahead of you to the good, as a dignity to myself and an act of self-denial on its behalf. But we go together. I console myself in you with what I keep back as honor for you, and I thank you for having dedicated me to this goodness."

"It is as though you were expecting this matter before today."

"This particular matter, no. But I am always expecting deliverance from God on every side — hoping for good in every quarter, listening with my ear to every speaker, and asking an increase from his words, whether he is right or wrong."

"An increase from the words of the truthful, we understand. But what do you ask from the words of the false?"

"An increase of truth upon truth is light. And recognizing falsehood for what it is increases certainty, and the greater the certainty, the greater the light of the heart. Only the people of certainty will be saved with God." Then he stood: "I am the one who rises to go to these people. If you are resolved to rise with me, then look: whoever knows a sin in himself, let him repent to God; whoever has a debt, let him pay it back to its owner; let each of you wash himself clean of impurity and put on the garments of the request — I have already purified the cloak of the bundles — and let him bring to the matter the intention of the needy. For if we go out to God and He knows our truthfulness, He will help us to attain His truth; and if He knows we have turned away from His signs in the lowest humiliation, then we have cleared the field for His friend, free of mockery."

"Yes," they said. "We will do what you have commanded — in three days."

"No."

"Two days, then?"

"Only today, if you will do it. Otherwise I go on alone."

"We repent to God from every sin," they said, "and we set aside what we owe, and we do what you have commanded — there is no power except in God."

So they did it from that very day, all of them, and they went out together until they came to the gate of al-Bakhtari. They greeted him, sat down, and Abu Malik turned to him.

"O Abu Salih — how is the good son? And where is he?"

Al-Bakhtari said, "Today my father is good, and I am the son of Salih. And he is good with his Lord."

Abu Malik thought Salih had died. He repeated the verse of return, "To God we belong and to Him we return," and asked again — had the boy died?

"Salih does not die, and will never die," said al-Bakhtari. "It is no figure of speech. The eternity remains."

Abu Malik turned to those with him. "These are three qualities whose meanings have been transposed," he said. "The child has become the father; the Lord is in the earth; and the Lord has a servant come to Him from him; and the one who created annihilation has become eternal. A whiff of perfume for perplexed students — and behind this lie further wonders."

"O Abu Malik," said al-Bakhtari, "name your need. Your question already places you at the threshold of an ordeal."

"I take it as given that the first truth is itself an ordeal. My need is a meeting with the righteous servant."

"There is no way to that — but did you mean my son, Salih?"

"Yes."

"That is with his permission."

So the sheikh got up at once and went in to his son and told him about Abu Malik and his companions, telling him what he knew of the virtue of their minds. And he prayed: "O God, open the hearts of Your servants and guide them by Your mercy to the signs of what is sought; and expand our chests with the light of Your veiled light." Then he wiped his hand over his face, cleared the council for them, and sent word back through his father.

When they entered, greeted him, and sat in order — Abu Malik and those below him taking their places by introduction — the first thing Salih said was this: "O Abu Malik, you have favored us with your visit and outstripped us to goodness with your generosity. Yet you were more deserving that we should have visited you, to preserve your affection and to discharge the duty long owed to you."

"When did you not do what is virtuous, O father of good?" said Abu Malik. "You have honored us when young and esteemed us when grown. You have become for us a caller and a warner to the good. Your root is good, your branch is high, your work is pure — so good fortune to you."

"Their nation has come to me, O Ka'b al-Ahbar," said Salih. "Is it imitation, then? Where is your perfect mind and the noble

understanding I have always credited to you?"

"Your stature is too high for mere prestige, and religion stands above imitation."

"How then can I have warners," said Salih, "when the warner is a prophet? And the prophet is an argument from God between Him and His creation, for them and against them. How then can he be an argument for you when he is not an argument against you?"

"I have come to believe — this is the obligation. We do not act on what is merely easy to say; we have begun with the best. I saw the truth before all else. He who has set himself up as a veil for religion and an imam for the truth has opened his doors to seekers. We have come to know the virtue of asking, so we sought you out and asked you for what was needed, intending you for our need."

"O Abu Malik — is not the one whose virtue you have come to know also one to whom you owe a debt?"

"Yes — and it is obligatory."

"And when you came to know the virtue of asking, did you also come to know its truth?"

"And what is its truth?"

"To know its faces — and then to seek what is obligatory upon you of the truth in each."

"What are its faces, and how many are they?"

"The seeking is of three faces," said Salih. "A seeker who knows. A seeker who does not know. And a seeker who knows that he does not know. Which of the three are you?"

"I am in need of knowing all three. How can I lay claim to a station I do not even know?"

"How then can you claim to be a seeker at all, if you do not know the faces of seeking?"

"I did not know them. So explain them to me."

"Money is the treasure of the people of this world," said Salih, "and knowledge is the treasure of the people of the Hereafter. The seeking of money is of three kinds: a seeker who asks for what is his by right, a seeker who asks for what is owed on terms, and a seeker who asks for alms — and the seeking of debt is the same. The treasures of the Hereafter are sought in three ways too. The first is the seeker who is himself a knower — the divine scholar — who seeks out the dead in their ignorance to revive them with his knowledge. The second is the seeker who knows — the learned man who has mastered certain degrees of knowledge and seeks their full end and limit; he is the knowing seeker. The third is the ignorant man who is known by his ignorance: he knows nothing beyond knowing that he is in need, so he asks the scholars in order to know. These are the three faces of seeking."

"Yes — these are the faces of seeking, in religion and in the world. As for me, I am the knowing seeker who knows nothing — only that he is in need. So make me know."

"Did you come knowing," asked Salih, "or did you come knowing by sight?"

"What is the difference between the two?"

"Knowledge by report is news. Knowledge by direct sight is eye-witness."

"This too is something one needs to know."

"As for the way of news," said Salih, "it is the case of an ignorant man who does not know he is ignorant until he meets a scholar, and the scholar tells him of his ignorance; then he knows he is an ignorant man in need of knowledge, by the scholar's word. His knowledge of his ignorance has come to him as report. As for knowledge of need and ignorance by direct sight — that is the man who already knows in his own mind that he is asking about something, but does not know the face of the answer. His chest is straitened by ignorance, and he hopes for no relief except by knowledge of what he is ignorant of; so his ignorance has itself become a knowledge of his mind. Ignorance is a need; poverty is the narrowness of need; distress is a great need that compels the creature to seek capacity. And capacity is the breadth of knowledge, because knowledge is wide. By this, I know that you are in need."

"I find within myself everything you have just described. I know that I am in dire need, and my need has been broken open by you."

"I see you hastening the request before it is firmly established."

"Poverty hastened me with its distress, and so I hastened it. I knew you to be the preferred bearer of capacity, and so I asked."

"If poverty has hastened you, and you know the bounty of capacity, then how do you know what is required of the request?"

"I have been graced by your grace; so I have come to you, and I have asked of you."

"How can it be true for you that I am known for capacity unless you first know it of me yourself? And how is it that I knew I was the one sought, so as to intend it for you? You have not seen me rub elbows with a scholar of prophecy, so as to know me by that; nor have you witnessed from me the proofs of evidence, so as to know me that way. Will you,

then, lift your request to the ease of imitation? In doing so you wrong wisdom, and you wrong yourself. You are like the man who leans on the bottom rail of the cage: if he cannot cut off the injustice of his opponent, then even greater injustice does the same to him. So too one who takes knowledge as a tradition: if he does not give thanks for it, and then leaves it, he is called a disbeliever. And you are wiser to me than this."

"I know that this is so. Yet I hope that the truth is what proves itself. I would absolve you from making the confirmation, since dispute breeds dispute and conflict breeds grudges — until each adversary demands his own opening over his opponent. When then will the truth finally take hold of one who is propped up by falsehood?"

"And I have not denied it," said Salih. "The truth does prove itself by its own merit and honor. But where rivalry is many, hearts are occupied with whoever speaks first. So there is no exception from what the scholars have laid down: every sowing whose ground is not first pleased with it gives no zakat, and every knowledge whose hearts are not purified for it by argument does not grow."

"Then call upon whatever arguments you wish. The words of wisdom are like the jewel — if you turn it over, its light shines; if you set it aside, its bounty does not fade."

"I believed you," said Salih. "But that is only if the jewel is indeed an essence, and not a camouflaged glass that has no essence hidden within it. If you let dispute multiply, and the conflicts of religion become the tyrants of the world, then they clothe the essence in something other than itself and camouflage it with a likeness — and the applicant is then obliged to test the essence for him, so that its true worth shows and the camouflage and its people are exposed."

"I have done justice and discharged the duty of truth. As for camouflage — we have come to know this creature and its defects, so we have rejected it, and have held fast to the opinion we have learned, and called the correct essence of speech. We have done so, and you have agreed with us, and we have all clung to its rope together. If you can find a meaning more inward than what lies in essence, then by my life, jewels are preferable, each in its own right. Show us where the virtue of your essence lies, by an ordeal known to reveal its virtue. As for our essence, we have known it and made it known. Say of it, then, whatever appears to you."

"As for your essence," said Salih, "it was generous of us to grant it to you as a correct essence — until we presented it to the essence-traders and the people of metals, and they tested it for us in the forge. They did not accept it from us as essence. They said it was glass in camouflage, and they pointed out its defects to us — and so it fell from the limits of essence. True essence rises by its own preciousness, by the knowledge of the people of insight, who give thanks for it and compete for it, so that its price reaches every sum. The essence-traders who know it, or come to recognize it afterward, do not turn it down — except the people of arrogance, who neither buy nor sell. So too with knowledge. It is not knowledge until it is presented to those who know the science of heaven. If they accept it, it is true knowledge; if they do not, it is nonsense. Idleness is not permitted in wisdom, nor accepted by the wise."

"And of those who know the science of the heavens — the prophets and messengers? We know of none of them in our time. The people have had no covenant with such men since revelation was cut off by the books. The nations are no longer condemned except by reports. What do you say to this?"

"Any religion established only on narration is not called a religion," said Salih. "Religion is what is valued by God and admits of no difference, while the narrations have not been revealed as a single body of truth — I know this from the disagreements among them and their denial of one another. The religion of God is dearer than that."

"If they differ in the narration," said Abu Malik, "they refer back to the books. Those who agree with the books accept it, and those who disagree have lied."

"But what if there is nothing in the books except the general — who then will make it specific for them? And what is detailed in them — who will deliver it to them? Who is trusted in matters of God's lawful and forbidden? I heard you on the day of the quarrel, when a man came to you — Maqrub — and said, O Abu Malik, I swore an oath of divorce and broke it. You said to him, Some people say she is forbidden to you and not lawful for you until she marries another husband, and some people say she is still your wife and is not forbidden to you by a single divorce. So the man said, Which of these should I act on? You said, Act on whichever of the two you wish. Yet he does not know whether what he goes home to is lawful or forbidden. Is this how rulings work in the religion of God? Is this how God's lawful and forbidden are determined?"

"The Sharia of my age has been lost," Abu Malik admitted, "corrupted, disrupted. We hold on only to the name of religion. What is the state of your religion?"

"And what is religion, O Abu Malik?"

"Command and prohibition, the lawful and the forbidden, the Sunnah and the obligations."

"And what is Sharia, in your view, other than this?"

"I do not know of anything beyond what I have described to you."

"So you have combined religion and Sharia into one thing?"

"Yes."

"Then religion has been disrupted by the suspension of the Sharia, and corrupted by its corruption — what is left with you?"

Abu Malik could not answer. He sat thinking about the matter of his own religion. Then at last he raised his head. "I do not see that anything is left with me. So what religion do you have?"

"Religion is with me, and I am not veiled from it. The corruptors opened its doors to the seekers, and the seeker remembered the first one who brought it and followed in good; he sought it, and through it works were honored, and through its justice the laws flourished. It is the cause that joins heaven to earth, unbroken — the loop of the firm handhold, the rope of those who hold fast, the ark of tranquility, the ship of life, the light of life, generous in its content, safeguarded in its sciences, marked in its jewels, its virtue hidden from no one who looks upon it."

"If God has a religion by which He will judge on the Day, with which He is pleased, and for which He rewards and punishes, then in that sense it exists. But now, since it has been lost, the attribute is preferable to him — so how is it described?"

"The good is only good, O Abu Malik," said Salih. "Place your light in the lamp-niche of your mind and grasp what is meant for you. You may have rights, and the robes of arrogance may have dazzled you, and you may have taken upon yourself what is not your own — what you have imitated from the ways of those who follow you in charity, so that they listened to your speech, accepted your guidance, trusted your opinion. It is your duty to protect yourself and them from a fire you cannot avoid

passing through; so seek a way to escape it. You are the most fortunate of them in God's grace and the most obligated to thank Him, for your task is to know the good and to hope for its reward. As for what you asked — confirming what I have called you to — it is incumbent on you to establish it from the aspects on which it can be founded."

"All that you have said is proven true. As for the narrations of the common people, they are not valid for religion and not suited to it. We are left with only the knowledge you call us to."

"I call you to God's justice and unity."

"Yes — what you call to, we shall affirm. We know its excellence above all doctrines."

"That is not where I am going, O Abu Malik. That doctrine which means only descriptions of justice without knowing the One described, and the use of God's names without knowing His Oneness — that is the doctrine I refuse. What I call you to is the knowledge of God's justice and the milestones of His unification. Once it is set forth, I will keep you from corrupting that saying as you wish."

"If the view of the people of justice is corrupt and their monotheism is denial, then there is no firm truth on the earth — except that the meaning is different across all the doctrines. Show us the corruption of justice and monotheism, and from where it comes."

"Justice and monotheism are among the noblest of all doctrines," said Salih. "Monotheism is too great to be corrupted, because there is no opposition to monotheism; and justice is not corrupted, because it is the judgment between God and His creation. But all the doctrines that have corrupted the saying of justice are themselves spoiled — claims by which no statement is proved, by people who do not know what they have said,

even as they say it so they may obey the command of God. Defend whichever doctrine you wish, then, and imitate it, until I strip it from you under the pretext of truth."

"I would not defend a statement I did not say," replied Abu Malik, "nor a statement the author was asked about, but not I. I do not set myself up as anyone's agent. I am not the author of these doctrines. I will defend before you only what I myself say. I say: God is One, nothing is like Him, just in His ruling, who does not burden His worshippers with what they cannot bear. He commanded and forbade them — not by absolute decree, nor by force, but by choice and warning — so the obedient did not obey by His trickery, and the disobedient did not disobey by His coercion. This is what I mean and what I say."

"Did I not tell you that this doctrine is among the noblest? But these are names and attributes of no use unless there is a meaning behind them. As when you say, fire is hot — you have believed the words, but the truth does not benefit you, because your saying fire is hot is the name of an attribute that does not benefit you unless the speakers cook food with it and light it; they remain in darkness without the meaning of fire being present. And if names and attributes stand in place of meanings — then let your tongue burn at the mere mention of fire, and let the mention of food satisfy you."

"As for these things, I have come to believe that names and attributes are of no use unless there is a meaning. So show me that my words about justice and monotheism are nouns and attributes that require knowing what is described."

"Your saying that God is One — and One is several letters; we see two letters joined and the rest separate. So which of them is one, or are they all together one? And you say that Allah is a name of four letters: is the

alif alone O God, or are all the letters together Allah — the evidence of God — or do you say otherwise?"

Abu Malik was struck silent.

At last he said, "I find no way out of this, except that each letter is a sign of God."

"Which letter indicates God? Or what is it that indicates God — the letters by their separation, or by their joining? Or singly and together — as you say that Allah is the alif alone and the three connected letters indicating God? Is this indication standing alone, or by their being joined?"

"I do not know what to tell you about this. Take us on to another chapter."

"The door to the knowledge of monotheism has been closed before you," said Salih. "Who said to you in this way, O Abu Malik?"

"Yes."

"Then I ask you about your knowledge of God — where is it from, and who took it? Is there an attribute that indicates a described one?"

"No."

"Does the one described have a name?"

"Yes."

"And what is the name that has been given to Him?"

"Allah."

"Is Allah a name, or the named?"

"It is the named."

"Then what is the name?"

"Allah."

"So Allah is a name for Allah."

"Yes."

"What is the difference between the name and the named? Which of the two is worshipped — or both?"

Abu Malik was perplexed and could not see his way to an answer. At last he said, "I find no doctrine in this except that I have seen all the crafts — each of them has a maker — and so I judged that this great creation has a Creator who is like nothing He has created, just as makers are not like the things they make."

"O Abu Malik," said Salih, "you have departed from the meaning of the Qur'an. The first issue is that the narrowness in the meaning of monotheism has forced you to seek Him by analogy and to set up parables for Him — and God is dearer than that, because everything made is made of three things, and God did not create things from anything that existed before them. As for these makers — you know them by watching some of them with your own eyes, how they make their things; so you judged about the making of something you did not see, judging a maker by what you observed of an action similar to the actions of the makers you have seen — by comparison. But when God created, you did not witness the creation of what He has made, nor did He set up a parable for His making in the manner of the makers — yet you have testified to a parable that is absent. What gives you the right, O Abu Malik, to be satisfied with analogy in your religion? How can you be satisfied with seeking the knowledge of your Lord by measurement? Your

saying nothing is like Him proves, from your own words, that He has a likeness and that nothing is like that likeness. Had you meant monotheism, you would have said, He is not like anything — not nothing is like Him. Glory be to the One whom no determination of thought can grasp, and whose sign no ambitions of perception can attain. The Almighty is too exalted for the description of those who are charged. O Abu Malik — if you intended by your question one of His servants or a king from among His angels, and you are unable to comprehend what is said about how he was created, then consider this: the lights of the people of the earth fall short of perceiving the light of the sun, and the sun is but one of the lights of the world. How shall one who falls short of perceiving a creature of His perceive the Creator? Say what seems right to you."

Abu Malik struck the ground in his confusion and could find no path through speech.

"O Abu Malik," said Salih, "raise your head and say what you have prepared to say."

"Speech is gone, there is nothing to say. Minds are confused about the answer, illusions are astonished by thought, the faculty is too weak — one can perceive Him only by request and inquiry."

"The One who is of such greatness," said Salih, "will sight perceive Him?"

"No, He is higher than that."

"Will speech be heard from Him?"

"There is no speech except from a speaker, and the speaker is described by words — and God is greater than such attributes."

"This Great, Most High One — is He unjust in His creation, so that He charges them with what they cannot bear and commands them with what they cannot grasp, and then punishes them if they do not?"

"Whoever charges the obedient one with what he cannot bear has laid a sin upon him, and his punishment is aggression — and God is dearer than that."

"The One who is too high above such injustice — would He be content with ignorance from those who serve Him as His servants?"

"Ignorance is a certain denial of thanksgiving and a continuation of disbelief," said Abu Malik. "And God does not love the unbelievers."

وَاللَّهُ لَا يُحِبُّ كُلَّ كَفَّارٍ أَثِيمٍ

"And God does not love every sinful disbeliever."

"Were they then created as scholars who already know what is wanted of them?"

"No — but He created them ignorant. They knew nothing."

"Then from where do they come to have knowledge of what He wants — making it obligatory upon them to please Him, and guarding them from His wrath?"

"They learned this from God."

"If He is higher than sight can reach, wider than perception can grasp, greater than the limits of speech — then how does the one whom He forbids and commands come to know what to do, so as to obey rather than disobey, to thank rather than disbelieve — unless you accept that there are causes for this knowledge between Him and His creation? Are

there not those who deliver His justice and bear witness to His witnessing for them and against them — whom He has chosen by His knowledge and selected from all His creation, made messengers to them and proofs against them, so that they stand as the just ones between Him and His servants, conveying His command and prohibition, so that obedience to them is obedience to God and His pleasure, and disobedience to them is His wrath and punishment? Otherwise — how could the command of God come to His creation at all?"

"This, for me, is among the foundations of justice," said Abu Malik. "As soon as creation needs God's justice to teach them what He wants from them through the hands of the righteous one whom He has created for that purpose, then each shall thank his benefactor, be rewarded by Him as He wills, be reproached by Him, and punished by Him if He wills."

"Is it permissible to rule with justice in any way other than this?"

"It is not permissible for anyone but God — and God is the wisest of judges."

"It would be permissible for Him, then," said Salih, "to delegate the command to some of His people — setting them up justly against their own wrongdoing — and then to assign two others to do the same thing, and so on without distinguishing them more justly than the first two?"

"The judgment can only be one," said Abu Malik, "because justice is one. If the ruling were divided into two meanings, one of them would inevitably perish."

"Has it not been established for you that the judgment of God is one, that there is no difference in it, and that it is one practice unchanged in His messengers? Were it not for the succession of the messengers, and

the commanding and forbidding, the Truth would have no growth and no meaning toward creation."

"Yes — this is the truth."

"And is not their repetition from God to His creation so that He may impose obedience upon them, and may make them an authority between Himself and His creatures, to bear witness for those who obey them — accepting their obedience — and to bear witness against those who disobey them, condemning them?"

"The judgment could not have been otherwise," said Abu Malik, "otherwise He would have falsified His messengers and broken His promise, and God is too generous for that. The command of the messengers has made clear that they are from His justice, and that people worship Him by obeying them. But tell me about these ranks: is it weightier with God for some of them to be superior to others, or not?"

"How could they stand level in rank when they are bound to obey one another? And were they on the same plane, with no disposition of obedience among them — then by His justice He has preferred some above others, so that obedience may be rendered from the virtuous to the more virtuous, and from the virtuous to the one above him, until it culminates. Thus they obey and worship to the utmost of what God wills."

"Is the one who obeys the virtuous among them, and the virtuous one himself, equal in reward?"

"Yes — this is the justice of God, which obliges every obedient one to receive his reward. One should not ask whether a virtuous limit or a curious limit applies."

"Is each of them like his counterpart?"

"No — because they come from the Creator with knowledge of the unseen — the Books that He has revealed to them — and no one can produce the like of them except from God."

"Then can anyone imitate the curious one among them, if no book is sent down to him in which knowledge of the unseen is revealed?"

"No one can claim that station."

"How could that be, when they did not display the seven creations of the unseen as the virtuous one himself displayed them?"

"If the virtuous one displays himself to others with knowledge of the unseen revealed in revelation, then the curious one likewise displays himself with knowledge of the unseen in the interpretation of the Qur'an. Whoever has it from God receives it and interprets it — and he receives nothing except from God by revelation."

"And the curious one is also inspired?"

"Yes — and therefore obedience to him became obedience to God."

"If you place him on a level with the virtuous one in obedience and revelation, why call him curious?"

"Because of the obedience due to the virtuous one, and the need for him."

"And what is his need for the creature, if the revelation comes from the Creator?"

"When revelation comes to him, he brings it with an interpretation of the hadiths, the books, and the rest of what the virtuous one left behind — as it was revealed to Lot at the hands of Abraham, and Abraham's virtue was made plain; and as it was revealed to Ishmael and Isaac, so that goodness, blessings, and credit accrued to Abraham. The revelation from

God is bound to His justice in His land, in proportion to their ranks. He does not, in His justice, will to cut off His command and prohibition and His worship after He has blessed people with it, so that worship would be cut off and ignorance permitted."

"The author of the revelation has shown his trustworthiness with knowledge of the unseen in his book," said Abu Malik. "Does the author of the interpretation likewise demonstrate that he has knowledge of the unseen — such that the revelation bears witness for him and obliges obedience to him uniquely, as it does for the bearer of the revelation?"

"He comes in his interpretation with knowledge from heaven and a declaration from on high — and the Book bears witness to it."

"I accept what the Books bear witness to — an interpretation that the revelation testifies to as revelation from God. Otherwise all the books and the messengers would have to be rejected, since their meaning is the same. If they give the lie to one another, all must be reckoned liars; and if they confirm one another, all must be believed."

"Such is justice," said Salih, "and by this one knows the honesty and virtue of those who believe in it. Obedience is obligatory to those who are confirmed to be among the messengers who are His justice in His creation and whom He assigned to convey His message. If obedience is obligatory by prophethood, revelation, and interpretation — then what about those who sit in their councils, who resemble them and yet are not them? They all agree that after their prophet there is no prophet and no warner in their time, and that they are the ones who obey the command of God and His religion, and that what they say leads to God's reward or punishment. You say otherwise. How could the scholars of this community fail to consider this period?"

"What they have left unexamined is not sound," said Salih. "They have no one to discuss it with them; they listen to it only with their own minds, while it has been drilled into their hearts that this is the first of the commands of God and His religion, and that there is no prophet after their prophet — just as the seducers of the nations before them said. Every nation has claimed that there is no prophet after its prophet."

"What was the origin of that, and what did they intend by it?"

"The originators of this were three, in every age," said Salih. "A wayward devil, a stubborn tyrant, and a hypocrite. By saying this, they sought to cut off the marks of the prophets from the features of prophethood and turn it into a station shared among themselves; but they could not, until they had instilled in the hearts of the nations the saying — addressed to every nation — that God did not send anyone better than your prophet, that there is no prophet after him, and no warner. So they whispered to them from a quarter they did not perceive, and led them off from a direction they did not know. Every nation clung to its own prophet by holding all others after him to be liars, supposing this drew them nearer to their prophet. Each nation claimed that every prophet who came after its own was a liar. Thus mention of prophethood and the prophets marks ceased among all the nations on the strength of that saying — and they did not seek what they had lost; nor would they have believed had they sought it. So the seducing devils were able to seduce those they seduced, and the powerful were able to kill the prophets, and they killed them; and the doubt-mongers among the corrupt jurists adorned themselves and were destroyed and destroyed others. All of this because no hearts inclined from creation toward the prophets when they appeared, and they did not seek them out when they were lost. So they despaired of the prophets, until they had to call to the truth aloud — and were called liars — and the prophets among them were killed in anger.

"This is the nation of the Magi, clinging to its tyranny, worshipping its idols upon its fire, saying — according to their claim — that God will not send a messenger after their messenger. This is the nation of the Torah, clinging to its books, working at its labor, standing within the bounds of its prophets, humble before its religion, saying that God will not raise up a messenger after Moses. This is the nation of the Gospel, by its analogy claiming that its prophet is its God, approaching with its crosses, glorifying its priests, saying that God will not send any messenger after Jesus. And this is your community — following the paths of those who came before it, seduced by what seduced them. It inherited the Book from other than its people, followed the religion without its people, followed its great ones, obeyed its masters in error, feared its tyrants and its jurists. So they established for them a religion other than the Sunnah — praying at a different time, paying zakat on something other than its proper due. They are patient with them, persistent in their need, certain in saying that God will not send any messenger or warner after their Messenger. So you and your peers followed the saying of the greater majority, and your patron was the abundance of consensus and the oppression of the sultans. You accepted it from them and sweetened it with the best of your doctrines, preferred it with the goodness of your words, made the argument from justice in what no argument can be made against you. So you held forth, supported from above by the mighty for prestige, while others follow you for desire, supposing this to be the truth.

"If this community must believe what it has decreed against God — that His arguments have been cut off from His creation by a single strand of consensus — then the nations are even more entitled to ratify three qualities by which they must hold an argument against you, and in which they must be more truthful than you."

"And what are these qualities," said Abu Malik, "that are obligatory for them — qualities we must believe in if what they say is true, or hold them to be liars in if what they say is false?"

"Their saying is like yours, and of the same kind. They say their hearts are like yours, and they have the standing against you in the argument. The first strand: they say they are earlier in the religion of God than you, and they have the merit of those who came before. The second: the consensus among themselves and with you to believe what they say — for they have the merit of being truthful. The third: your own testimony to them that their prophets are truthful and that they are the messengers of God; and none of them has testified for any prophet of yours, neither to prophethood nor to truthfulness. They have a standing against you by your unanimity with them that what you possess of knowledge is copied from their knowledge — and theirs is the origin of your knowledge. This is their argument against you. It is clear that justice in the rule of creation is obligatory upon the Creator; the judgment of these people is obligatory; and if the Creator, the ruler of His creation, abrogates what He wills and confirms what He wills, no one's ruling outranks His. Every man's saying falls away, and the Creator is foremost over creation and over the command — and every day He is engaged in some affair, and His action is not to be denied, even if He sends a warner every day."

"This community has gone far astray," said Abu Malik.

"Most of the first two went astray before them," said Salih, "for they cast off the guardians of God, abandoned their rights, and allowed the foolish among them to prevail in their command, so they made lawful what God had forbidden, deliberately, lest they have to imitate prophethood — so people might lose track of the prophets and not kill them on that account. Yet they distracted them with kingship and largesse and led them to indulge their whims. Those known for honesty and piety on the

surface helped them in this — until the community was stripped of those who would command good, and led toward those who would forbid it. They called the partisans of falsehood the guardians of God, so that truth became falsehood — like light and darkness in their difference. Were it not for the remnants of God's guardians and His justice in the earth, and the revelation that comes to them, only a few of the honest would have remained against the many of the false. Otherwise — by what could God distinguish the evil from the good, except by His servants? And how could God's argument be conveyed to all creation, except through them?"

"There is no escape and no avoidance of the justice of God and His command," said Abu Malik. "With the multiplicity of opposites, none but the just servants of God remain — and by them the argument of God against His creation is upheld."

"Then it is established that the company is of the prophets of God — namely, the just ones — and is the one among them called the just?"

"Yes — he is the just one, as it is said: So-and-so testified, and he was just among the just."

"It has been established for you, then, that the just one is the guardian of God — to the extent that you say it as a description, and the description holds?"

"Yes — this is true as a saying."

"And whoever does not understand the one being described — will the description benefit him?"

"The description does not benefit him except by understanding the described."

"Then whoever does not know the just one of God and His guardian — will his speech be just?"

Abu Malik smiled, and I would have you see his smile, because there is a kind of smile that a man gives when he has been beaten by something he loves. "You have brought me out of my chapter on justice and monotheism," he said, "and what has brought me out is the truth itself, in the clearest of arguments and the kindest of speech. After this, what chapter remains to be proved?"

"From here, O Abu Malik," said Salih, "the camouflaged glass falls away from those who deal in the colors of jewels — they could not recognize its virtue. When the truth is set before me, the essentialists are exposed, and those who are deceived by them are exposed."

"I have believed and acted accordingly. But how shall we be safe from the seducers of the nations, and how shall we know the causes of God, or the cause among them, when we do not perceive them in their time — and in our time there are neither prophets nor messengers, as there were in the nations before us?"

"Glory be to God, O Abu Malik," said Salih. "You keep speaking of the justice of God at every moment of your life — yet as soon as We have proved it to you in your own presence, where it is obligatory upon you, you turn back and say you would be deceived about God, and attribute injustice to Him."

"God forbid — whoever says such a thing has transgressed. He has lied against God. Where did you take me as committed to that?"

"You say the age of the prophets has passed and that in our time there is neither prophet nor messenger. Was the sending of those earlier two ranks simply for the sake of being worshipped — or was it in vain?"

"May God forbid — only what is just issues from Him."

"Then what has excluded us from that justice? Are we not worshippers as they were? They were created as we are created; we are bound in service as they were bound. Has the obligation been lifted from us after it was binding on them? Or has the giving run out in our time, so that we cling to Him only by virtue of what was given to them? Or has the Sunnah of God changed in our case after being firmly established in those who came before us — so that we should judge that God has changed? Or is justice a duty upon us, while its instrument is left lawful for us to neglect, when it was forbidden to those before us — when there is no substitute for the words of God and no overruling of His judgment? And who deserves the name just except the guardians of God? Justice is not found among those God created, except in those whom God Himself chose — they became just by His command. That is why a judge is called just for the sake of the one who appointed him, and a true word is called truthful because of the truthfulness of the one who speaks it."

"It is indeed so," said Abu Malik. "We are not permitted to say anything of God except the truth. Were we to follow our own opinion in speech and judgment, in the absence of the rightly-guided among us, we would have abandoned His judgment. This is part of God's ruling and His Sunnah with us, just as it was with those before us during the interregna between one messenger and the next — like the period between Abraham and the time of Moses and the Torah, and the period between the Torah and the time of Jesus and the Gospel. We have been on that same footing, working through the interregnum by relying on the traditions and the Sunnah."

"The religion of God is too precious to Him for that," said Salih. "Was there really an interregnum after the religion of Abraham — when God sent after him Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Jonah, and Shu'ayb, leading

up to Moses? He inspired them with righteous deeds and the call to the religion of Abraham, the establishment of prayer by its Sunnah, the giving of zakat by its obligation — until the Torah was given to Moses. And what interregnum stood between Moses and the Gospel, when God sent after Moses Joshua son of Nun, and Elias, Talut, David, Solomon, Zechariah, and John, leading up to Jesus? They stood by the ruling of the Torah in its religion, calling to it and reciting its Psalms, until the Gospel was revealed to Jesus. So with those who passed before them and those who came after them. We have seen great evidence among them — only God knows their full count — and their messengers brought them proofs. God did not leave them; He set parables for them; He was the One calling them to the truth. So where is this interregnum, and when was it? God Himself said —

عَلَىٰ فِتْرَةٍ مِّنَ الرُّسُلِ

"after a succession of messengers"

— and so confirmed the messengers. The period after the rising of the call came after fear, so they prayed in secret and concealment. Why then would they cut themselves off from the earth? God has made it so that in the blink of an eye they are either openly present or hidden in fear, veiled."

"This is an irrefutable statement," said Abu Malik, "a proven word in which there is no doubt. As for the proof of God's argument through justice and the succession of messengers — that has been established and confirmed. What then is the meaning of their absence in our own time?"

"What was the reason for Moses absence when he went out of Pharaoh's city and passed in fear, waiting until he reached the land of Shu'ayb?"

"He fled from Pharaoh's people, hiding from them, because he feared for himself when they had agreed to kill him."

"And have you heard that any of the just — the just ones of God and the sons of His prophets — were killed while patiently bearing the burdens of the religion?"

"Yes — many of them have been killed."

"Then what is the justice of this age that appears to you and to the people of your time? Is there one whom God sends down to you after death? Or one fleeing among you whom you would force back to the killing he escaped, when he has followed God's example in His prophets and messengers — patient under fear and concealment until God judges between him and us, and He is the best of judges?"

"There is no shame on the one who follows the Sunnah of the righteous by fearing for himself and fleeing from his people," said Abu Malik. "The shame is on the wicked nations and the helpers of the darknesses for killing the prophets of God and His just ones, and for their unanimous agreement upon that act."

"What do you say about one who kills the just of God and His proof? Where is his end? And what of the one who helped him?"

"Both are in the Fire — and so too is anyone who raised a banner or carried a flag in their cause."

"What do your jurists say about this?"

"They show mercy to the slain, but see no disobedience in the killer."

"Whoever obeys the killer voluntarily — is he not a partner with him in the blood of the slain?"

"Yes, by God — he is his partner, and even more wicked than he."

"His companionship is acknowledged in his helping the killer — so how is he not worse than him?"

"Were it not for the narrations of the jurists," said Abu Malik, "no tyrannical king could ever be established."

"You have spoken the truth, O Abu Malik," said Salih. "I have laid this on you yourself: with their king, their house, their land, and their soldiers stationed as your neighbors, while we have been taken as their slaves. And you are their just ones — you judge them by your knowledge, you uphold their kingship, you have called them by your questioning, and you have thanked them for what you needed from them. You placed on their stockings the crown of your justice, and they grew proud; you covered their clay with the robes of the sacred law, and they went too far; you lit up their falsehood with the idleness of your truth. So the weak were enraged by your conduct — those who were scholars like you — and they said, These are the jurists of the umma; we have in them an example. You went astray by your own reasoning, and you led others astray by the reasoning of the mighty. You supposed the one really in office was someone other than yourself, and you forgot the words of God Almighty —

وَلَا تَرْكَبُوا إِلَى الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا فَتَمَسَّكُمُ النَّارُ

"And do not incline toward those who have done wrong, lest the Fire touch you."

So you severed what God commanded to be joined, while seeing it, and you spoke about the outward forms of justice while being confused by it. You came across His saying —

أَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَأَطِيعُوا الرَّسُولَ وَأُولِي الْأَمْرِ مِنْكُمْ

"Obey God, and obey the Messenger, and those in authority among you"

— and you made these darknesses your authorities, even when they disbelieved. And you forgot the words of God Almighty —

قَاتِلُوا الَّذِينَ يَلُونَكُمْ مِنَ الْكُفَّارِ

"Fight those of the disbelievers who are near to you"

— so you disobeyed those you were commanded to obey, and obeyed those you were commanded to fight, all the while thinking you were doing well. So you have nullified and gone too far. Your opinion has even reached the point of claiming that God will not send a messenger or a warner in your age. Is it that the goodness of your deeds has put you beyond need of the guardians of God for the argument? Or has the ugliness of your deeds cut you off from hope in God's acceptance of repentance? Or is it just to judge God without justice — and to be satisfied for your Messenger with what you would not be satisfied with for yourselves in his place? Would any one of you accept that his fifteen-year-old son be killed, or that his house and money be taken from him unjustly?"

"No one is satisfied with that," said Abu Malik. "Even when one of us has a child killed, or is driven out of his property by the anger and rage of his

people, we do not consider ourselves content."

"God and His Messenger have a right that you be angry on their behalf — if His vicegerent is killed and His guardian is driven out of the land."

"It is dear to us that the guardian of God be killed among us or driven from his land. But they have deliberately absented themselves from us, and the mighty have appeared in their place."

"Had you supported the friends of God, they would have appeared. Had you failed His enemies, they would not have prevailed. But the verdict has bound you to the guardians of God in three ways: the killer of the ruler does not tire of seeking and is not healed even when his case is nailed down — he is content with the stinging bite at his fingertips, out of anger; they do not stir up their enemy and do not turn from them even in their heedlessness; and out of hatred — because they believe in love for the guardians of God — they have no insight into faith and no trustworthiness in confidentiality. For this reason the guardians of God have absented themselves from you by taqiyya. For this reason, also, the great creatures who took their own desires as their god, and seized the goods of this world, have done what is on a par with killing the prophets. They were ignorant of the fault of their conduct, so they did not hold themselves accountable for the injustice they committed and were not humbled into repentance for what they had done; instead, they returned to attributing the injustice of their own deeds to God, and said: God will not send messengers after these thirteen messengers, nor will He send a warner. So they made the killing of the guardians of God lawful unjustly — they were indeed unjust, and they wronged Him by that saying and by promising a lie."

"Yes," said Abu Malik. "This is the description of this nation of ours, and this is exactly what they say. Where is the salvation from this — where is

the escape from the punishment of God?"

"By God — take refuge in Him and repent to Him; He accepts repentance from you. Ask Him for the way of His guardians, and He will save you by your works from the deeds of those who have done wrong. So it is with this creation: if they repent to God, He accepts their repentance. And what does God do with His punishment of them then?"

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يَظْلِمُ مِثْقَالَ ذَرَّةٍ

"Indeed God does not oppress by the weight of an atom"

— even when they are unjust and lie; and He does not hasten them with punishment, even when they hasten to commit disobedience."

"I seek refuge from the punishment of God," said Abu Malik, "by repenting to Him and seeking the means to His satisfaction. That belongs to the student in you and to the guide in his guidance — your Lord will reward you."

"If you do that," said Salih, "you will find God pardoning of you. He loves repentance. And you will find me careful in guiding you, watchful over you."

Then Salih's eyes welled with tears at the mention of repentance, and he broke off his speech. He encouraged them, and ordered them to go to his father's house. And he himself went in to his father — the scholar who had first sent him out — and consulted him about the matter of Abu Malik and his companions.

The scholar said: "You know your companions. If you know what is best for them, guide them with your guidance; and when you warn them, do not let it move you to inflict ta'zir upon them. Test them by ignoring

them without ignorance, and instruct your elders to be kind to them and act righteously toward them in due time. The one who desires good is not hidden, and God will not abandon you behind your back; He will open for you, from the light of His success, the gates of guidance that He has appointed for him, and will show you the deeds of those who turn back to Him."

So Abu Malik and his companions differed in their state of affairs, each in his own way, until orders came to them and they recognized their own guidance and the kindness shown toward it — and God is their guardian. They thanked God, they returned to their people as warners, and God guided whomever He willed of His servants to His religion.

10. The Author's Word

What I have set before you in the shape of a story was never a story for its own sake. I did not draw out the days of these men, nor follow them through their wanderings and their meetings and their partings, because I wished to entertain you or to fill the page with incident. I told it because a narrative, when it is true, is a confirmation of what God has commanded. The lives of the messengers, the bearing of the guardians who came after them, the manners of those who set out seeking — these things do not arrive in the soul as bare propositions. They arrive walking, eating, speaking, hesitating, repenting, returning. If I had given you only the doctrine without the men who carried it, you would have held an empty cup. And so the account that has passed before you is, in its every turn, a witness: that the messengers stood firm, that the guardians bore the signs entrusted to them, and that the seekers, when they were sincere, were taught the manners by which a seeker is known.

Praise belongs to God, the First and the Last — the One before whom there was nothing and after whom there is nothing, the One whose praise is the beginning of every speech worth speaking and the seal of every speech that has reached its end. May God send His blessing upon His Messenger Muhammad, whom He sent forth from Himself to His creation as a bearer of good news and a warner; and upon his guardian, the Imam of the God-fearing, the leader of those who emigrated for God's sake, the beloved of the Lord of the Worlds; and upon the Imams of the people of his house, those whom God has favoured and from whom He has lifted every defilement and purified with a complete purifying — as He Himself has said of them:

إِنَّمَا يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيُذْهِبَ عَنْكُمُ الرِّجْسَ أَهْلَ الْبَيْتِ وَيُطَهِّرَكُمْ تَطْهِيرًا

"God only desires to remove defilement from you, O People of the House, and to purify you with a complete purifying."

God is enough for us. Blessed is the Agent who acts on our behalf, blessed is the Lord who owns our affair, blessed is the Supporter who stands by those who have no other stay. There is no power to turn from what harms, and no strength to hold to what benefits, except by God, the High, the Mighty:

لَا حَوْلَ وَلَا قُوَّةَ إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ الْعَلِيِّ الْعَظِيمِ

"There is no power and no strength except by God, the High, the Mighty."